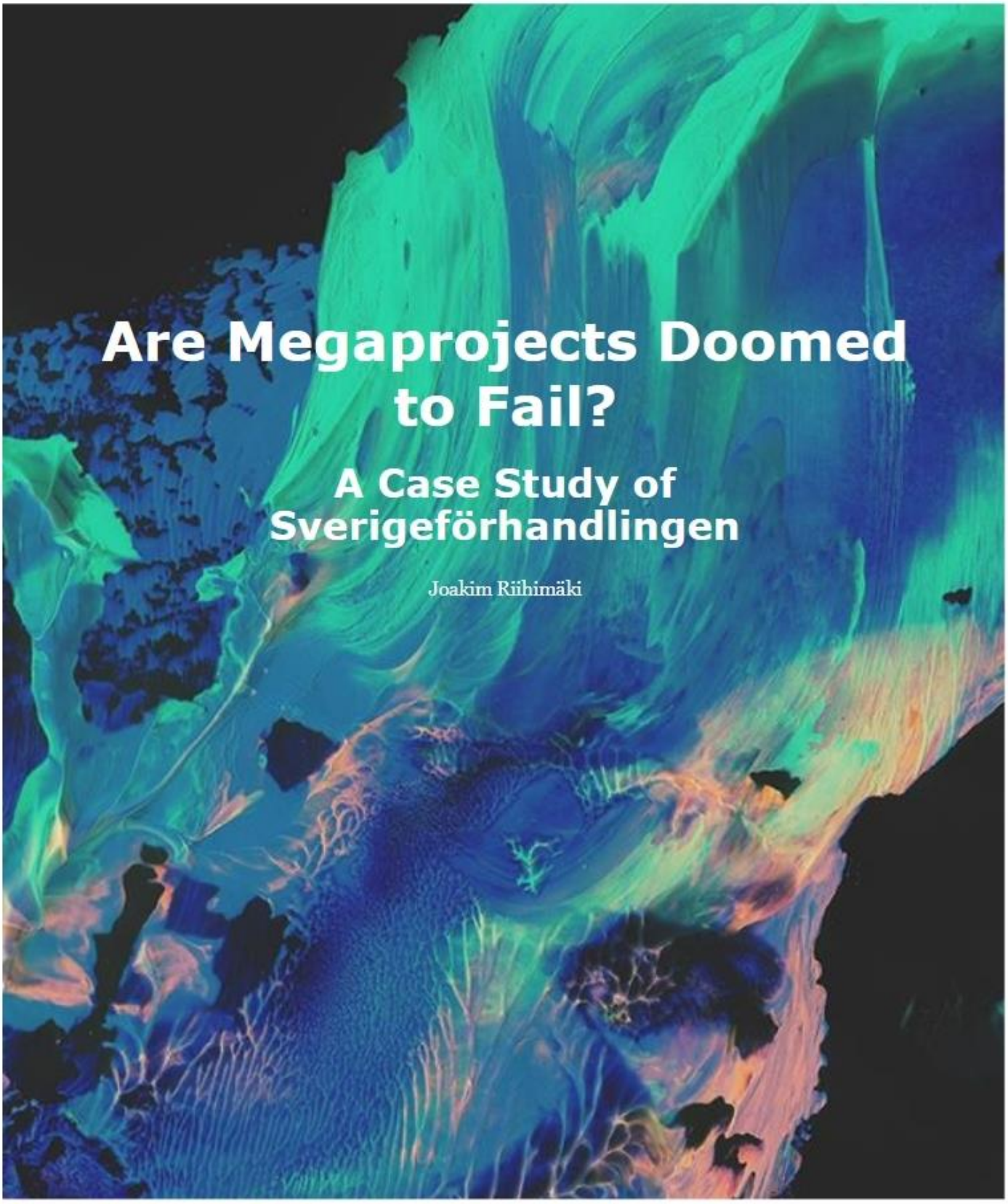
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Abstract

This thesis examines the implementation problems of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, known as Sverigeförhandlingen, and why the project was not implemented as was originally intended. The study uses a qualitative single-case design and document analysis to examine the governance process between 2014 and 2025. Five theoretically derived analytical characteristics structures the empirical analysis: inadequate economic models, conflicts between stakeholders, external influence, unrealistic scheduling and political failure. The findings show that problems within all five characteristics were present in the case, but their importance is mainly in how they interacted and reinforced each other. Many of the problems were connected to decisions made during the initial design of the project. Together path dependency, policy network theory and implementation research help explain how early political commitments, relationships between actors and implementation conditions contributed to the project's problems. Based on these findings, the thesis presents recommendations concerning analytical requirements, realistic scheduling and resources, stakeholder coordination and continuity in the objectives and governance of future Swedish megaprojects.

Keywords

The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, Sverigeförhandlingen, megaprojects, failure, policy analysis, Implementation, infrastructure governance, stakeholders, housing, high-speed rail, Sweden, governance

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1. Introduction

Large-scale infrastructure projects represent some of the most complex undertakings in governance. They demand sustained political commitment, coordination across multiple institutional levels and substantial public resources over extended time. But despite these demands, the literature consistently shows that large-scale infrastructure projects fail to meet their stated objectives. This raises a question: why do large-scale infrastructure projects consistently fail to deliver on their intended objectives, and what can be done? Sweden's National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure (known in Swedish as Sverigeförhandlingen) provides a valuable case for examining this question. The project was initiated by the Swedish government in 2014, the negotiation was given a broad mandate which involved to plan and secure financing for new high-speed rail between Stockholm, Gothenburg and Malmö while simultaneously negotiating housing construction deals with regions and municipalities along the planned routes.[1] Despite years of negotiations, debates, extensive analyses and a series of formal agreements the project has not been implemented as was originally intended.

Three concepts are central to this thesis and require explanation early on. The first is the concept of a megaproject. Megaprojects are generally defined in terms of its financial budget (one billion dollars or more) but researchers argue that cost alone is insufficient to define megaprojects.[2] Megaprojects are better understood as large-scale and complex involving multiple public and private stakeholders, highly ambitious and long development periods. The second concept is policy failure. A policy fails when it does not achieve its main goals and when support is weak or opposition is strong. This also means a policy can succeed in some areas while still failing overall.[3] The third concept is implementation, which refers to how political decisions are carried out in practice. Instead of a direct translation of political aims, implementation is shaped by interactions between actors, institutions and political conditions. Which often is leading to outcomes that differ from the original goals.[4] The National

[1] Statens offentliga utredningar, *Infrastruktur och bostäder – ett gemensamt samhällsbygge: Slutrapport från Sverigeförhandlingen*, SOU 2017:107 (Stockholm: Finansdepartementet, 2017), P. 13–15.
[2] Bent Flyvbjerg, "What You Should Know About Megaprojects and Why: An Overview", *Project Management Journal*, vol. 45, no. 2 (2014), P. 6.
[3] Allan McConnell, "What is policy failure? A primer to help navigate the maze", *Public Policy and Administration*, vol. 30, no. 3–4 (2015), P. 226.
[4] Pressman & Aaron Wildavsky, *Implementation: How Great Expectations in Washington Are Dashed in Oakland; Or, Why It's Amazing that Federal Programs Work at All*, 3rd edn (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), P. xxiii.

Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is therefore analysed both as a megaproject and as a policy process where implementation problems and political decisions contributed to outcomes that differed from the project's original objectives.

1.1 Problem formulation

The academic problem addressed in this thesis comes from tension in the present research. Megaproject research shows that megaprojects suffer from cost overruns, delays, lost benefits and flawed planning assessments.[5] Implementation research has similarly shown that the gap between political ambitions and actual outcomes is a common feature of complex policy processes involving multiple actors. This gap is influenced by aspects such as the number of actors involved and the availability of resources throughout implementation.[6] Policy failure research has also established that failures are rarely absolute but instead matters of degree where a policy may succeed in some aspects but failing in its primary objectives.[7] Despite this knowledge across these fields, less is known about how the patterns they identify interact in specific political and institutional contexts especially in ongoing projects. Existing research has identified many of the individual problems linked to megaproject failure, meanwhile implementation research has shown that various factors can interact during implementation. The remaining analytical problem is therefore not primarily to identify new types of failure but to understand how established problems develop and reinforce each other within a governance process over time. The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure provides an appropriate case for examining these issues. As a Swedish megaproject with governance and decision-making that are well documented in official reports, audits and evaluations, it makes it possible to trace how different types of failure emerge and reinforce each other throughout the implementation process. In order to understand these interactions, it requires consideration of different levels of the same governance process. Path dependency gives this thesis a perspective in order to examine how early political and institutional commitments can influence later decisions and make changing direction increasingly difficult.[8] Policy network theory provides a way to examine coordination and conflict between national, regional and municipal actors with different interests, resources and access to decision-making.[9] Implementation

[5] Flyvbjerg 2014, P. 9-11.
[6] Pressman, Wildavsky, 1984, P. xxiii.
[7] McConnell, 2015, P. 226.
[8] Paul Pierson, "Increasing Returns, Path Dependence, and the Study of Politics," American Political Science Review, vol. 94, no. 2 (2000), P. 252–253, 261–262.
[9] R. A. W. Rhodes & David Marsh, "New Directions in the Study of Policy Networks," European Journal of Political Research, vol. 21, no. 1–2 (1992), P. 182, 186–188.

research focuses on the process among political objectives and actual outcomes and how resources and interactions between actors can influence implementation.[10] These perspectives are used together in this thesis to examine how earlier decisions, relationships between actors and implementation conditions shaped the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure.

1.2 Aim

The aim of this thesis is to investigate why the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure has not been implemented as originally intended by analysing how five theoretically derived failure characteristics are manifested and interact throughout the project's implementation process, and to present recommendations for how future Swedish megaprojects can be better designed to avoid similar outcomes.

1.3 Research Questions

- How are the five analytical failure characteristics manifested in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and how do they interact to shape the project's outcomes?
- How can the identified failures be explained through path dependency, policy network theory and implementation research?
- Based on the findings from the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, what recommendations can be presented to improve the planning and implementation of future Swedish megaprojects?

1.4 Outline

Chapter two presents the literature review and theoretical framework, introducing the analytical characteristics used to structure the empirical analysis and positioning the study within existing work on megaprojects, policy failure and implementation. Chapter three discusses the methodological approach, research design and the selection and handling of empirical material. Chapter four presents the empirical analysis, organised according to the five analytical characteristics. Chapter five offers conclusions and a discussion of the findings.

[10] Michael Hill & Peter L. Hupe, Implementing Public Policy: Governance in Theory and in Practice (London: SAGE Publications, 2002), P. 7–8, 50.

2. Literature, Theory and Analytical Framework

This chapter is divided into two parts. The first presents previous research relevant to megaproject failure and policy failure and is organized thematically. The second part presents the theoretical framework developed for this thesis and introduces the theoretical concepts. The purpose of keeping these parts separate is to explain what is already known in the area and where this thesis makes its own analytical contribution.

2.1 Previous Research

2.1.1 The characteristics of megaprojects

Mega projects are commonly described as large and complex that typically cost at least one billion US dollars, take many years to complete, involve multiple public and private actors and affect large populations.[11] In this thesis, the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is classified as a megaproject based on both its scale and complexity. Its budget far surpasses the standard for infrastructure projects, while its governance involves a diverse range of national, regional and municipal stakeholders with differing interests. This long-term, multi-actor involvement reflects the exact type of complexity that Pitsis et al. define as a feature of megaprojects.[12] The global scale and frequency of megaprojects has increased significantly which is a trend Flyvbjerg attributes in part to the "four sublimes": the technological sublime pushing engineers toward groundbreaking construction, the political sublime where politicians use megaprojects to build legacy and visibility, the economic sublime framing them as drivers of growth and the aesthetic sublime drawing public admiration toward iconic structures.[13] These sublimes aids in explaining why megaprojects gather political and public support even when their economic motivation is uncertain.

2.1.2 How and why megaprojects fail

The literature consistently shows that megaprojects fail to meet their stated objectives far more often than they succeed in doing so. Flyvbjerg's analysis of megaproject identifies what they call the "iron law" which identifies that cost overruns, time delays and benefit losses are not random or uncommon outcomes but patterns that are systematic and that persist across different

[11] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 6.
[12] Alexandra Pitsis, Stewart Clegg, Daphne Freeder, Shankar Sankaran & Stephen Burdon, "Megaprojects Redefined – Complexity vs Cost and Social Imperatives", *International Journal of Managing Projects in Business*, vol. 11, no. 1 (2018), P. 5-7.
[13] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 8–9.

project types and national contexts.[14] Flyvbjerg identifies optimism bias which is the systematic tendency to underestimate costs and overestimate benefits during planning as one of the primary drivers. This often goes together with strategic misrepresentation, which is where supporters deliberately provide favourable estimates to ensure political approval. Flyvbjerg's "survival of the unfittest" concept defines how the projects that appear most promising on paper are often those most likely to be approved because their costs have been the most underestimated and their benefits most overestimated.[15] Flyvbjerg's findings are confirmed and expanded upon in a Swedish context by Ronnle whose doctoral dissertation examines how megaprojects are justified to maintain political support even when their economic reasonings are inadequate.[16] Ronnle identifies four justification strategies that are occurring in the high-speed rail project: expanding a project's scope to create ambiguity and attract a wider range of supporters. Replacing unfavourable cost-benefit analyses with optimistic alternatives.[17] Negotiating with stakeholders to build regional and political legitimacy,[18] and using persuasive narratives that connect the project to broader social and environmental objectives.[19] These strategies built political and regional support for the project despite its negative cost-benefit results.[20]

Scheduling and cost overruns are also a well-documented recurring problem in megaprojects. Flyvbjerg shows that only one in ten megaprojects is delivered on schedule,[21] and that unrealistic timelines are a widespread characteristic.[22] Locatelli also shows that megaproject delays are connected to project complexity and that projects can underestimate the time and resources required for implementation.[23] Mohammed and Bello identify poor planning and scheduling as sources of construction delays, delays will also contribute to cost overruns and loss of public confidence.[24] Mancini shows that European megaprojects are susceptible to external risks related to political change, public debt pressure and evolving regulatory requirements which can create uncertainty and contribute to delays or changes in the project.[25]

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[14] Ibid, P. 9–11
[15] Ibid, P. 14-17.
[16] Erik Ronnle, *Justifying Mega-Projects – An Analysis of the Swedish High-Speed Rail Project* (Doctoral thesis, Lund University, 2019), P. 14.
[17] Ibid, P. 54-55.
[18] Ibid, P. 56.
[19] Ibid, P. 57.
[20] Ibid, P. 65–66.
[21] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 12.
[22] Ibid P. 11.
[23] Giorgio Locatelli, *Why are Megaprojects, Including Nuclear Power Plants, Delivered Overbudget and Late? Reasons and Remedies*, Report MIT-ANP-TR-172 (Cambridge, MA: Center for Advanced Nuclear Energy Systems (CANES), Massachusetts Institute of Technology, 2018), P. 1-2. 21.
[24] Zayyanu Mohammed & Umar Bello, "Causes of Delay in Construction Projects: A Systematic Review", *International Journal of Engineering Research & Technology (IJERT)*, vol. 11, no. 3 (2022), P. 63-65.
[25] Mauro Mancini, "European Megaprojects: Managing Contextual Uncertainty through the Stakeholder Management" (Report, Politecnico di Milano, Italy, 2014), P. 1-3, 5-7.

Magwedere and Marozva argue that the main barrier to successful infrastructure delivery is often not a lack of financing but a lacking in infrastructure governance, with high sunk costs making megaprojects uniquely vulnerable to political risk.[26]

2.1.3 Policy failure as analytical tools

McConnell argues that policy failure is characteristically difficult to define because it is multidimensional and context reliant. If a policy has failed depends on which objectives are prioritized, the point in the policy timeline and whose perspective outcomes are evaluated from.[27] McConnell emphasizes that failure is rarely all or nothing and that policies might succeed in some aspects while also failing in others and what defines as failure depend on the values and positions of those making the assessment.[28] McConnell's definition shows this complexity: "a policy fails, even if it is successful in some minimal respects, if it does not fundamentally achieve the goals that proponents set out to achieve, and opposition is great and/or support is virtually non-existent".[29] This thesis defines failure as a matter of degree instead than "success or failure". This perspective is particularly relevant to the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure where some elements of the project have advanced while the proposed high-speed rail system have not progress to construction.

Mueller argues that public policies work in complex and non-linear systems. In these systems, outcomes cannot be reliably predicted because policies constantly evolve along each other. Actors also respond to interventions in ways that change the conditions the policies are meant to address.[30] Mueller identifies multiple pathologies of policy failure that includes: cognitive bias among decisionmakers, a tendency to treat complex systems as simple and linear and failure to account for actor reactivity. This happens when municipalities, regions and other stakeholders adapt their behaviour to incentive structures in ways that undermine the policy's original goals.[31] Mueller argues that policymakers should abandon top-down approaches and rather adopt adaptive, flexible and decentralized strategies.[32] These findings from Mueller are particularly relevant to understanding how the National Negotiation on Housing and

[26] Margaret Rutendo Magwedere & Godfrey Marozva, "Does political risk matter for infrastructure investments? Empirical evidence", *Development Studies Research*, vol. 10, no. 1 (2023), P. 2.
[27] McConnell, 2015, P. 223.
[28] Ibid, P. 226-227.
[29] Ibid, P. 230.
[30] Bernardo Mueller, "Why public policies fail: Policymaking under complexity", *EconomiA*, vol. 21, no. 2 (2020), P. 314-315.
[31] Ibid, P. 316-317.
[32] Ibid, P. 321-322.

Infrastructure co-financing model generated unintended incentive effects. Le Grand's theory of government failure provides an additional relevant perspective for this thesis where they argue that governments interventions can fail to allocate resources efficiently and equally,[33] they also highlight that the level of government failure must be proven through evidence and must not be assumed beforehand.[34]

2.1.4 Implementation Research and its Limitations

The foundational study by Pressman and Wildavsky's is a central part of implementation research and shows how implementation becomes more difficult as the number of decisions and actors whose agreement is required increases.[35] Hill and Hupe describe the field's main focus as understanding what happens between policy expectations and policy results.[36] Since these two works implementation research has developed into a broader field examining factors such as policy design, resources, relationships between organizations, institutional conditions and actor behaviour. Howlett demonstrates how the field developed across several generations of research which includes the debate between top-down and bottom-up approaches and efforts to integrate implementation more with broader policy-process research, which was a later subject in the field.[37] Howlett argues that implementation research has generated extensive knowledge about implementation events but it has stayed theoretically split and inadequately integrated with broader theories of the policy process.[38] Because of this implementation has to be understood as part of the larger policy process and not as a simple implementation of decisions made during an earlier stage.[39] But recent studies show that this criticism is not completely accurate. Sætren and Radlick's review of implementation research exhibits substantial progress in research design and methodological diversity and also describe the field as "mature and thriving".[40] They note that theoretical development has not advanced to the same extent, and that implementation research has not converged around a single framework as expected.[41] They argue that further progress can come from connecting implementation research more strongly to the more wider policy-

[33] Julian Le Grand, "The Theory of Government Failure", *British Journal of Political Science*, vol. 21, no. 4 (1991), P. 423-424.
[34] Ibid, P. 442.
[35] Pressman & Wildavsky, 1984, P. 102–108.
[36] Hill & Hupe, 2002, P. 2.
[37] Michael Howlett, "Moving Policy Implementation Theory Forward: A Multiple Streams/Critical Juncture Approach," Public Policy and Administration, vol. 34, no. 4 (2019), P. 407–409.
[38] Ibid, P. 405–406.
[39] Ibid, P. 411–413.
[40] Harald Sætren & Rebecca Lynn Radlick, "Moving Beyond Third Generation Policy Implementation Research Towards a Fourth Generation: Synthesizing Across Policy Process Theories," Policy Studies Journal, vol. 54 (2026), P. 3–4.
[41] Ibid, P. 1–2.

process theories.[42] Their review also shows that longitudinal research remains uncommon with it making up around a quarter of empirical implementation studies across the three generations that were examined.[43] These developments presented are important for positioning this thesis. This thesis does not assume that implementation research has ignored the interaction between different implementation factors. Hill and Hupe clearly emphasise that even though parts of the implementation process may need to be analysed separately, the several involved variables interact and the process then needs to be understood as a whole.[44] The contribution of this thesis is instead to examine how several established implementation problems developed and reinforced each other over time within the governance of an ongoing Swedish megaproject. Combining path dependency and policy network theory with implementation research helps explain these interactions across time and across relationships

2.2 Knowledge Gap and This Thesis's Contribution

Implementation research already recognises that policy outcomes are shaped by multiple interacting circumstances and as recent reviews show that the field has advanced extensively in methodological diversity and research design.[45] But the fields theoretical convergence are still incomplete while also the longitudinal designs continue to be in a minority of implementation studies.[46] The research from mainly Ronnle on the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure has mainly focused on how the high-speed rail project was justified and how analytical material was used in decision-making.[47] This thesis will instead examine implementation across the project's development from 2014 to 2025 and analyses how problems within five analytical characteristics developed and reinforced each other over time. The contribution is then not the identification of completely new types of implementation failures but the application of a theoretical framework to examine their interaction within a ongoing Swedish megaproject. Path dependency, policy network theory and implementation research are combined to provide temporal, relational and process-based explanations of these patterns.

[42] Ibid, P. 4–5.
[43] Ibid, P. 3.
[44] Hill & Hupe, 2002, P. 137.
[45] Sætren & Radlick, 2026, P. 3–4.
[46] Sætren & Radlick, 2026, P. 1–4. Howlett, 2019, P. 405–406.
[47] Ronnle, 2019, P. 15.

2.3 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework combines path dependency, policy network theory and implementation research. These three perspectives are used together to explain different political, institutional and governance aspects of megaproject implementation. From this framework five analytical characteristics are created to structure the empirical analysis.

2.3.1 Path dependency

Path dependency explains how early events can put political and institutional processes on a path that becomes increasingly difficult to change. Mahoney explains self-reinforcing sequences where early events are followed by mechanisms that replicate an institutional pattern over time. A critical juncture happens when one option is chosen from several alternatives and returning to the earlier alternatives becomes increasingly more and more difficult.[48] Pierson applies this onto politics and argues that increasing returns raise the costs of changing to another path. Political institutions are also often resistant to change, which can strengthen this effect over time.[49] In this thesis, path dependency is used to examine whether early political commitments and institutional arrangements made later reassessment of the project more difficult.

2.3.2 Policy network theory

Policy network theory focuses on how actor who are dependent on each other interact during policymaking. Rhodes and Marsh argue that these relationships depend on what different organisations control and how much they rely on one another.[50] Power and access can be uneven, while some networks are characterised by competition and conflict between actors.[51] In this thesis, policy network theory is used to examine how differences in resources, interests and access between national, regional and municipal actors influenced stakeholder conflict and coordination problems.

2.3.3 Implementation research

Implementation research shows that going from political decisions to outcomes is rarely linear but is shaped by complex institutional and systemic factors. Pressman and Wildavsky's foundational implementation research demonstrates that implementation is best understood as "a process of interaction between the setting of goals and the actions geared to achieving them"

[48] Mahoney, 2000, P. 512–513.
[49] Pierson, 2000, P. 252–253, 261–262.
[50] Rhodes & Marsh, 1992, P. 182.
[51] Ibid. P. 186–188.

[52] and that the likelihood of successful implementation declines as the number of required decisions and clearances involving different actors increases.[53] A central finding in implementation literature is that the possibility of implementation deficits increases as policies require approval and coordination across multiple clearance points. The more clearance points that are introduced presents the possibility of delays, modifications or even failure.[54] Hill and Hupe describe implementation as a process in which policy can continue to be shaped through interaction between actors.[55] Their review of Hogwood and Gunn also highlights adequate time and resources, clear objectives, detailed responsibilities and coordination as important conditions for implementation.[56]

2.3.4 Combining the Theoretical Perspectives

The three theoretical perspectives are not opposing explanations but are used together because they address different dimensions of the same implementation process. When combining these perspectives, it is also consistent with recent developments in implementation research. Howlett argues that implementation research benefits from being connected more closely to wider theories of the policy process and Sætren and Radlick also says that theoretical synthesis as an important path for further development of implementation research.[57] The theoretical combination in this thesis is not proposed by these authors but follows the logic of using complementary theoretical perspectives to understand different parts of a complex implementation process. The theories and the five analytical characteristics have different functions in the thesis. The five characteristics are used to identify and organise empirical implementation problems while the three theoretical perspectives are used to explain the mechanisms and relationships behind the identified patterns.

2.4 The five analytical characteristics

Building on the theoretical framework and previous research, this thesis develops five analytical characteristics to structure the empirical analysis. They are not hypotheses or empirical findings, but analytical categories used to identify and organise relevant implementation problems in the material. The categories are not mutually exclusive, the same observation may relate to more than one characteristic. This allows the analysis to examine how different problems interact and reinforce each other.

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[52] Pressman, Wildavsky, P. xxiii.
[53] Ibid, P. 102–108.
[54] Ibid, P. 102–108.
[55] Hill & Hupe, 2002, P. 7–8.
[56] Ibid, P. 50.
[57] Howlett, 2019, P. 411–413. Sætren & Radlick, 2026, P. 4–5.

2.4.1 Inadequate economic models

The first analytical characteristic, inadequate economic models, is grounded in research on economic mismanagement in megaprojects and on the limitations of decision support tools in policy implementation. Flyvbjerg demonstrates that megaprojects regularly experience cost overruns and benefit shortfalls and that errors and biases in "forecasts" can make the economic analyses used in decision-making misleading.[58] Mackie and Preston identify multiple persistent sources of error and bias in transport appraisal, including model errors and excluded effects.[59] Pancotti et al. shows that weaknesses in transport appraisal can result from missing data, omitted effects and institutional problems. They also argue that clear methodological requirements and established standards improve the comparability of appraisals.[60] Hill and Hupe's discussion of Hogwood and Gunn highlight the importance of adequate resources and clear objectives during implementation.[61]

2.4.2 Conflicts between stakeholders

The second analytical characteristic, conflicts between stakeholders, is grounded in research on policy failure and policy network theory. McConnell identifies the failure to garner support from key stakeholders as a central mechanism policies fail through, arguing that when actors with diverging interests fail to meet, implementation is weakened.[62] Rhodes and Marsh provide a theoretical foundation for understanding why conflicts occur. They argue that policymaking characteristically takes place within policy networks rather than through hierarchical processes, and that these networks consist of actors with unequal resources, influence and access to decision-making arenas. As a result of this, interactions within policy networks are characterised by negotiation, mutual dependence and unbalanced power. These policy networks consist of a spectrum of actors including central governments, public agencies, municipalities and local authorities. Differences in resources and access can therefore create competition and conflict within policy networks.[63] Hill and Hupe describe implementation as a process of interaction and negotiation between the actors involved in putting policy into effect.[64]

[58] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 9-10.
[59] Mackie & Preston, 1998, P. 3–6.
[60] Pancotti et al., 2019, P. 4, 29.
[61] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 50,
[62] McConnell, 2015, P. 227.
[63] Rhodes, Marsh, 1992. P. 188.
[64] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 7.

2.4.3 External influence

The third analytical characteristic, external influence, refers to political, economic and institutional conditions around the project that can affect implementation. McConnell notes that policies can be pushed off course by circumstances outside the policy itself, while Mancini shows that megaprojects can be affected by political and regulatory change and economic conditions.[65] Hill and Hupe also emphasise that implementation takes place within a wider political and institutional context.[66] In this thesis external influence is used to examine these influences and if some were partly created or strengthened by the project's own governance design. Mancini's research on European megaprojects shows that those projects are particularly susceptible to external risks related to political change, public debt pressure and changing regulatory requirements all of which can cause delay.[67] From the implementation perspective Hill and Hupe emphasise that implementation is shaped by the wider political, institutional and economic context in which it takes place.[68] Magwedere and Marozva further demonstrate that infrastructure projects are uniquely susceptible to political risk due to their high sunk costs and argue that the main barrier to successful infrastructure projects is often not a lack of financing, but a shortage in infrastructure governance.[69]

2.4.4 Unrealistic scheduling

The fourth analytical characteristic, unrealistic scheduling, is grounded in research consistently identifying time management as a recurring and major challenge in megaprojects. Flyvbjerg's research shows that only one in ten megaprojects is delivered on schedule, and that the use of unrealistic or overly optimistic scheduling is widespread in megaprojects.[70] Locatelli's research also shows that megaproject delays are connected to project complexity and that projects can underestimate the time and resources required for implementation.[71] Mohammed and Bello further identify poor planning and scheduling among recurring causes of construction delays, while delays can also contribute to cost overruns and loss of public confidence.[72] From the implementation perspective Hill and Hupe's discussion of Hogwood and Gunn highlights sufficient time and resources as well as coordination between actors are important conditions

[65] McConnell, 2015, P. 225; Mancini, 2014, P. 1–3, 6–7.
[66] Hill & Hupe, 2002, P. 181–183.
[67] Mancini, 2014, P. 1-3. 5-7.
[68] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 181-183.
[69] Magwedere, Godfrey, 2023, P. 2.
[70] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 9, 11-12.
[71] Locatelli, 2018, P. 11-13.
[72] Mohammed, Bello, 2022, P. 63-65

for implementation.[73] Pressman and Wildavsky also shows how complicated implementation processes involving several decisions and actors can create delays that make implementation more difficult.[74]

2.4.5 Political failure

The fifth analytical characteristic, political failure, is grounded in research on the role of political decision-making in shaping megaprojects and path dependency. McConnell argues that policy failure can take different forms, including problems in the political process and cases where policies are not implemented as intended or fail to achieve their goals.[75] Flyvbjerg argues that megaprojects can give politicians visibility and attention which can create incentives to initiate and support them.[76] Pierson's research on path dependency in political processes provides a theoretical explanation for why political commitments to megaprojects endure even after their problems have become apparent. Rising costs can make changing paths costly, while political institutions can also make it harder to change an already established direction.[77] Hill and Hupe describe the difference between expected and achieved outcomes as an implementation gap.[78]

2.5 Summary of the five characteristics

Table 1 summarises the five analytical characteristics used to structure the empirical analysis.

Characteristics	Description
Inadequate economic models	This characteristic refers to weaknesses in the project's economic analyses and decision-support material, such as incomplete assessments, inconsistent methods or omitted effects. These problems can make the material less reliable and more difficult to compare. It draws on megaproject and transport appraisal research together with implementation research on the importance of clear objectives and a valid analytical basis.
Conflicts between stakeholders	This characteristic refers to disagreements and coordination problems between actors, including the state, agencies, regions and municipalities. Different interests, unequal resources and unequal access can make cooperation and coordination more difficult. It draws mainly on policy network theory and implementation research on interaction between co-dependent actors.
External influence	This characteristic refers to political, economic or institutional conditions surrounding the project that influence decision-making and project conditions. These can include political change, economic conditions and other circumstances outside the project's direct control. It draws on policy failure and implementation research on the wider context in which implementation takes place.

[73] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 50.
[74] Pressman, Wildavsky, 1984. P. 110-116.
[75] McConnell, 2015, P. 236.
[76] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 9.
[77] Pierson, 2000, P. 252-253. 262-263.
[78] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 10.

Unrealistic scheduling	This characteristic refers to plans and implementation schedules that underestimate the complexity and practical demands of large infrastructure projects. It captures gaps between political expectations about timing and the time required for analysis, coordination and implementation. It draws on megaproject and implementation research on optimistic scheduling and delays in complex multi-actor processes.
Political failure	This characteristic refers to situations where political decisions and commitments contribute to gaps between stated goals and implementation. It also includes cases where earlier commitments make later reassessment more difficult. It draws on policy failure research, path dependency and implementation research on the gap between expected and achieved outcomes.

Table 1

3. Method and Research Design

3.1 Research Design

For this thesis to be able to answer its research questions a qualitative single case study design has been used. The research questions ask how the five analytical failure characteristics are manifested within the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, how they interact with one another, how these patterns can be theoretically explained and what recommendations can be drawn for future Swedish megaprojects. These research questions require an in-depth analysis of a policy process over time which makes a case study the most suitable design. A case study is appropriate when the research questions require an in-depth examination of how implementation problems developed and interacted within a specific political and institutional context. Yin argues that case studies are particularly appropriate when the study tackles how or why questions, when the researcher has little control over the events being studied and when the focus is on a "contemporary phenomenon" within its context. This applies to the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure which evolved over time through political choices, institutions, external events and various stakeholders.[79]

A methodological challenge of this thesis is that the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is an ongoing project. This raises the question of how implementation can be studied before it is complete. Hill and Hupe argue that when policies continue to change during implementation, qualitative case studies are useful because they can follow how the process develops over time.[80] This thesis addresses this by treating the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure as a case where the governance decisions and their consequences are documented in adequate detail to allow systematic analysis. The analysis focuses on how failure

[79] Robert K. Yin, Case Study Research and Applications: Design and Methods, 6th edn (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications, 2018), P. 33. 50.
[80] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 147-148.

characteristics developed and interacted across the projects governance timeline instead of evaluating a finished result. The findings should be understood as reflecting the state of the project up to 2025 and not a definitive assessment of its final outcome. The use of a single-case design allows for a detailed analysis of interactions between political, institutional, actors and implementation factors within one governance context. Flyvbjerg argues that strategically chosen cases can build theory without relying on statistical samples. The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is especially useful because its continued implementation problems, continuous political commitment and wide documentation provide a rich case for examining how different governance problems develop and reinforce each other.[81]

In this thesis, the case is defined as the governance process initiated through the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, including the 2014–2017 negotiation period and the subsequent implementation, reassessment and renegotiation of the agreements through 2025. The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is treated as the main case, while individual projects, actors and political actors are examined as parts of that case. The thesis therefore examines implementation difficulties and deviation from stated objectives across the wider governance process instead of assuming that every component of the National Negotiation failed.

The analytical approach for this thesis is mainly theory driven. The five analytical characteristics were developed from the theoretical framework before the systematic coding of the material and provided the main structure for the analysis. During the initial reading, the definitions and empirical indicators used for each characteristic were refined, while the five characteristics remained as the predefined coding categories. [82] The approach is primarily deductive but empirically informed instead of strictly deductive or inductive. The theoretical framework works as the basis for the coding scheme and guides what patterns in the empirical material are examined. This use of theory prior to the systematic analysis is in line with Yin's case-study approach where theory development during the research-design stage provides direction for the collection and analysis of evidence. According to Yin this requirement holds regardless of whether the research seeks to generate or test theory.[83] The study also includes a temporal perspective by examining developments between 2014 and 2025, but time is not

[81] Bent Flyvbjerg, "Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research", *Qualitative Inquiry*, vol. 12, no. 2 (2006), P. 222, 229-231.
[82] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, P. 54–55.
[83] Yin, 2018, P. 75-77.

treated as a separate analytical focus. The analysis does not systematically compare developments at fixed points in time. Instead, timing is considered when relevant, mainly in relation to when assessments and political decisions were produced and at what stage of the implementation process.[84] This helps to examine how governance problems developed and interacted during the project. This is also consistent with Hill and Hupe's argument that policy formation and implementation are ongoing processes in which policies may be reformulated during implementation.[85] The three research questions guide different parts of the analysis. The first examines how the five analytical characteristics appear and interact in the empirical material. The second explains these patterns through path dependency, policy network theory and implementation research. The third uses the identified governance problems and their theoretical explanations to create recommendations for future Swedish megaprojects.

3.2 Material Selection and Source Considerations

The material was selected according to its relevance to the research questions and analytical framework, its connection to developments during the 2014–2025 period and its ability to provide evidence about project governance, economic assessment, stakeholder relations, scheduling or political decision-making.[86] Material was identified through searches of publicly available documents from the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure own website, the Swedish Transport Administration, the Swedish Government and the Swedish Riksdag. Additional documents were identified through keyword searches using terms including *Sverigeförhandlingen, Sverigeförhandlingen Nyheter, Sverigeförhandlingen rapport*, *Sverigeförhandlingen analys, the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure* and *Sverigeförhandlingen redovisning*. Material was selected according to its relevance to the research questions and analytical framework, its connection to developments in the 2014–2025 time period and how it provided evidence about project governance, economic assessment, stakeholder relations, scheduling or political decision-making. This follows Bergström and Boréus argument that the selection of textual material should be justified in relation to the research question and the conclusions.[87] The process may have excluded relevant material due to time constraints of the thesis. All material that met the selection criteria was considered during the coding process but not every coded passage is presented in Chapter 4. When multiple documents supported the same analytical pattern, representative examples were selected in

[84] Yin, 2018, P. 73.
[85] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 147-148.
[86] Yin, 2018, P. 108. Bowen, 2009, P. 33.
[87] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, p. 88

order to avoid repetition. Choosing which examples to present was separate from coding the data. All coded material still shaped the analysis. By using several types of material allows evidence to be compared across different institutional perspectives. Yin means that the use of multiple sources is a strength of case-study research because findings can be supported through converging evidence rather than depending on a single source. When it was possible, evidence from different types of documents is used to support the same analytical findings.[88] To trace development over time, the material is interpreted in relation to the stage of the project it was produced: mandate establishment, the negotiation period, the period following the final report and the later period of reassessment and renegotiation. These phases are not treated as separate analytical categories but are used to determine the series between events and to identify problems that occurred simultaneously from cases where one problem contributed to a later problem.

3.3 Material introduction

The material used in this thesis can be divided into three main source types. The first category consists of official government and agency documents, including government directives, state investigation reports, audit reports and evaluations. These function as primary sources documenting the formal governance decisions, economic assessments and institutional evaluations that shaped the project. The second category consists of parliamentary sources including interpellation debates, written questions and ministerial responses. These function as primary sources for documenting how political actors engaged with or responded to the project's challenges in the Riksdag. The third category consists of media sources and expert commentary. These work as supplementary sources documenting how the project's problems were understood and criticised outside governance process. Together these three categories provide material that covers the governance from the initial mandate to the most recent political developments in 2025.

Dir. 2014:106 is the government directive from July 2014 that set the formal mandate, objectives, scope and timeline for the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. This thesis uses it as a primary source for the original political commitments and scheduling expectations against which the project's later development is assessed.[89]

[88] Yin, 2018, P. 196–197.
[89] Kommittédirektiv, *Utbyggnad av nya stambanor samt åtgärder för bostäder och ökad tillgänglighet i storstäderna*, Dir. 2014:106 (Stockholm: Näringsdepartementet, 2014)

SOU 2017:107 is the final report submitted in December 2017 by the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures negotiators. It presents the project's own account of cost estimates, socio-economic analyses and negotiation outcomes. This thesis uses it as a primary source for an internal look of the project's governance and challenges.[90]

The Swedish Transport Administration's 2016 socio-economic assessment was produced within the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and presents a cost-benefit analysis of the proposed high-speed rail based on the assumptions available at the time. It is used in this thesis to document the economic information available during the negotiation phase.[91]

The Swedish Transport Administration's 2021 position paper provides a more detailed socio-economic assessment of the proposed high-speed rail corridors. It is used alongside the 2016 analysis to show how cost estimates and profitability assessments developed over time.[92]

The Swedish National Audit Office report RiR 2021:15 examines the city agreements within the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, focusing on public transport investments in Stockholm, Gothenburg and Malmö. It is used to show how the project's governance and cost management were assessed by an independent oversight body.[93]

The social benefits report by Karin Winter summarises benefit assessments from regions and municipalities prepared for negotiations in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. It is used to assess the quality and consistency of the analytical material produced by actors in the project.[94]

The Swedish Agency for Public Management 2022 report evaluates negotiation mandates as a governance tool for addressing major societal challenges. It is used to show how an independent agency assessed the negotiation model and its outcomes.[95]

The interpellation debate on 14 February 2017 between Erik Ottoson (M) and Infrastructure Minister Anna Johansson (S) records positions in the Riksdag on the project's socio-economic assessments during the negotiation phase. It is used as a primary source for the political failure and inadequate economic models' characteristics.[96]

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[90] SOU 2017:107

[91] Trafikverket, *Samhällsekonomisk kalkyl av höghastighetsjärnväg enligt Sverigeförhandlingen 2016-02-01*, Ref: TRV 2014/54842 (Borlänge: Trafikverket, 2016)

[92] Trafikverket, *Samlad effektbedömning: Ny stambana, höghastighetståg (Järna–Almedal, Jönköping–Lund), positionspapperet*, Object: JTR2205 (Borlänge: Trafikverket, 2021), P. 1.
Riksrevisionen, *Statlig medfinansiering av regional kollektivtrafik – Sverigeförhandlingens storstadsavtal*, RiR 2021:15 (Stockholm: Riksrevisionen, 2021), P. 20.

[94] Karin Winter, *Sociala nyttor i Sverigeförhandlingen*, Report TRITA-SoM 2015-12 (Stockholm: KTH Royal Institute of Technology, 2015), P. 7.

[95] Statskontoret (2022). Förhandlingsuppdrag som metod för att lösa stora samhällsutmaningar. (Publication 2022:10). Stockholm: Swedish Agency for Public Management.), P. 13.

[96] Riksdagen, Interpellationsdebatt, *Höghastighetståg*, 14 februari 2017. Anförande 73–79. Available at: https://www.riksdagen.se/sv/webb-tv/video/interpellationsdebatt/hoghastighetstag_h410249/

Written question and response 2020/21:2970 records Infrastructure Minister Tomas Eneroth's reply to parliamentary scrutiny of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures outcomes. It is used as a primary source for the political failure characteristic.[97]

SVT Nyheter, *"Nya järnvägen inte värd pengarna"* (May 2016) includes a statement from Professor Jonas Eliasson at KTH about the scope and design of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure's mandate. It is used to document independent expert commentary during the negotiation phase.[98]

SVT Nyheter, "Höghastighetståg en förlustaffär enligt forskare" (November 2019) reports on a debate article by six transport economists who conclude that high-speed rail in Sweden is socio-economically unprofitable. It is used to document independent expert criticism of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure's economic justification.[99]

SVT Nyheter, "Infrastrukturministern försvarar satsningen på höghastighetståg" (November 2019) reports Infrastructure Minister Tomas Eneroth's response to the researchers' critique. It is used alongside the article to show how political actors responded to expert analysis in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure.[100]

The government press release from March 2025 announces a negotiator to renegotiate the Stockholm agreements in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure due to rising costs. It is used to document the latest development in the project's governance.[101]

Written questions from Riksdag members, including Leif Nysmed (S), Linus Lakso (MP), and Fredrik Lindahl (SD), to infrastructure ministers document parliamentary scrutiny of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure across different governments. They are used to show the political consequences of cost overruns.[102]

Two articles from Mitt i Stockholm (June 2024 and January 2021) include statements from local officials and opposition politicians about renegotiations in the National Negotiation on Housing

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[97] Riksdagen, Svar på skriftlig fråga 2020/21:2970, *Sverigeförhandlingen och kollektivtrafiken*, besvarad av Infrastrukturminister Tomas Eneroth (S). Available at: https://www.riksdagen.se/sv/dokument-och-lagar/dokument/svar-pa-skriftlig-fraga/sverigeforhandlingen-och-kollektivtrafiken_h8122970/

[98] SVT Nyheter, *"Nya järnvägen inte värd pengarna"*, 29 maj 2016. Available at: https://www.svt.se/nyheter/lokalt/jonkoping/inte-vart-pengarna

[99] SVT Nyheter (2019a). *"Höghastighetståg en förlustaffär enligt forskare"*, 7 november 2019. Available at: https://www.svt.se/nyheter/ekonomi/hoghastighetstag-en-forlustaffar-enligt-forskare

[100] SVT Nyheter (2019b). *"Infrastrukturministern försvarar satsningen på höghastighetståg"*, 7 november 2019. Available at: https://www.svt.se/nyheter/infrastrukturministerns-forsvarar-satsningen-pa-hoghastighetstag

[101] Regeringskansliet, *Förhandlare ska omförhandla avtal om Stockholms infrastruktur och utreda finansiering av Östlig förbindelse*, Press Release, 13 March (Stockholm: Government Offices, 2025).

[102] Leif Nysmed (S), *Skriftlig fråga 2023/24:987 – Spårväg syd*, to Statsrådet Andreas Carlson (KD), submitted 13 June 2024, answered 28 June 2024, Riksdagen. Nysmed, L. (S), *Skriftlig fråga, – Extra resurser till Spårväg syd*, to to Statsrådet Andreas Carlson (KD). Fredrik Lindahl (SD), *Skriftlig fråga 2020/21:1233 – Omförhandlingen av Sverigeförhandlingen*, to Infrastrukturminister Tomas Eneroth (S), submitted 12 January 2021, answered 20 January 2021

and Infrastructure and their effects on housing development. They are used to show stakeholder-level consequences of governance failures.[103]

3.4 Qualitative Content Analysis

To analyse the documentary material, this thesis applies a qualitative content analysis as part of a qualitative document-based approach. Bowen defines document analysis as a systematic procedure for reviewing and evaluating documents where the material is examined and interpreted to develop empirical knowledge.[104] They also notes that document analysis is particularly relevant to a qualitative case study where documents can provide empirical evidence about a specific organisation or process.[105] Bergström and Boréus note that content analysis can be understood broadly as the systematic analysis of textual content, and that qualitative content analysis can refer to forms of analysis where the material is not quantified or measured. The frequency of an observation is therefore not treated as a measure of its analytical importance, since an individual decision or political statement may be significant even if it occurs only once.[106] In this thesis, the method is used in this broader qualitative sense. The purpose is not to measure how frequently particular problems occur, but to systematically identify and interpret documented decisions, assessments and governance problems in relation to the analytical framework.[107] Textual material can also be used to study political and administrative processes rather than only ideas or language. Bergström and Boréus point out that government decisions and proposals are formed through texts, making documentary analysis relevant for studying how governments operate. The documents in this thesis are then used both to reconstruct decisions and developments in the project and to examine how these developments were assessed by the involved institutions and actors.[108] Because of this the analysis has two connected roles. First the documents are used to reconstruct the documented development of the project, formal decisions, assessments, agreements and changes over time. This use is also supported by Bowens work who identifies tracking change and development over time as one of the specific jobs of documentary analysis.[109] Second qualitative content analysis is used to interpret these documented developments in relation to the five analytical

[103] "Framtidens nya bostäder hotade", *Mitt i*, 29 January 2021, available at: https://www.mitti.se/nyheter/framtidens-nya-bostader-hotade-6.27.5194.558bcafbf6 (accessed: 1 August 2025).
[104] Glenn A. Bowen, "Document Analysis as a Qualitative Research Method," Qualitative Research Journal, vol. 9, no. 2 (2009), P. 27.
[105] Ibid. P. 29.
[106] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, P. 80.
[107] Kristina Boréus & Göran Bergström (eds), *Textens mening och makt: Metodbok i samhällsvetenskaplig text- och diskursanalys*, 3rd edn (Lund: Studentlitteratur, 2012), P. 50.
[108] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, P. 18.
[109] Bowen, 2009, P. 30.

characteristics. The method is used to systematically analyse a political and administrative process through documentary material. They are analysed based on who produced them, their purpose and when in the project they were produced. Yin warns that documentary evidence should not automatically be treated as a literal record of events and should when possible be compared with evidence from other sources.[110] A qualitative approach is also suitable because the interaction between governance problems cannot be fully captured through measurable variables. Hill and Hupe argue that qualitative methods are useful when important processes are difficult to quantify and require interpretation.[111]

The five analytical characteristics functioned as the coding categories. Bergström and Boréus describe a coding scheme as an analytical instrument indicating what should be identified and recorded in the material.[112] Bowen explains that document analysis involves identifying relevant passages and organising them into categories connected to the research questions. Predefined codes can also be used to structure the analysis.[113] The documents were first read to establish context and relevance to the research questions. Relevant passages were then recorded in a structured Excel file together with the source, page reference, date and analytical characteristic. The coded material was then compared across documents to identify recurring patterns and links between the characteristics. The coding file was also used to organise and store the empirical material separately from the final thesis.[114] The coding file also uses a documented connection between the empirical material and the claims in the analysis. Yin describes this as maintaining a chain of evidence, where the reader should, in principle, be able to trace conclusions back through the evidence to the original research questions. Recording the source and location of coded material increases the transparency and reliability of the analysis.[115] Qualitative text analysis inevitably involves interpretive judgement, mainly when the meaning of a text depends on its context.[116] The analytical characteristics are not mutually exclusive, and the same observation can be coded under more than one characteristic. Overlapping coding was used to identify possible relationships between the characteristics, but overlap alone was not treated as evidence that the problems interacted. An interaction was

[110] Yin, 2018, P. 108. Bowen, 2009, P. 33.
[111] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 144.
[112] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, P. 54-55
[113] Bowen, 2009, P. 32.
[114] Yin, 2018, P. 201.
[115] Yin, 2018, P. 206–207.
[116] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, P. 82–86

identified when the material directly connected two problems or when several sources supported the same connection.

3.5 Thesis Limitations

Several limitations of this thesis must be acknowledged in order to properly contextualize the findings and identify guidelines for further research on the subject. **The ongoing nature:** A central limitation is that the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is still an ongoing project. This gives this thesis a relatively unique analytical angle but also means that the empirical material is not complete. The results should be understood as reflecting the state of the project up to 2025. **Single case study and generalizability:** A second limitation concerns generalizability. The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is a single case and is not treated as a statistical sample of all megaprojects. Yin argues that case studies are not meant to statistically represent all cases. Instead, their findings can be used to understand broader theoretical patterns. The findings from this thesis may therefore help explain similar governance processes.[117] The analytical framework was developed for application to the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and is not purposefully designed to perfectly fit every mega project assessment. **Research bias:** A further limitation concerns the interpretive nature of the analysis. Decisions about which passages are relevant and how they relate to the analytical characteristics involve researcher judgement. Bergström and Boréus emphasise that interpretive text analysis requires consistency and transparency so that the reader can follow how the researcher moved from the empirical material to a conclusion.[118] The use of defined analytical characteristics, systematic coding and recorded source and page references reduces this problem, although another researcher could still interpret parts of the material differently. **Use of secondary sources:** The reliance on written material also creates a limitation. Bergström and Boréus note that texts provide only part of the information needed to understand political decision-making.[119] The sources used in this thesis provide extensive evidence about formal decisions, assessments and documented conflicts, but they cannot fully capture informal negotiations or undocumented motivations of the actors involved. **Scope of analysis**: The study is deliberately limited to the five analytical characteristics and does not attempt to provide a complete evaluation of every possible cause of implementation difficulty.[120] This delimitation

[117] Yin, 2018, P. 78–79.
[118] Bergström & Boréus, 2012, P. 41–43.
[119] Ibid. P. 20.
[120] Carol H. Weiss, *Evaluation Research: Methods for Assessing Program Effectiveness* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1972), P. 15.

allows the selected governance problems to be examined in greater depth, but other factors may also have influenced the project.[121]

4. Empirical data and analysis

The presentation of the material in this chapter is structured according to the five analytical characteristics developed in chapter two. All quotes in this chapter have been translated from Swedish into English using translating software. The empirical observations may relate to more than one characteristic. Instead of treating the characteristics as isolated explanations, the framework is used to structure interpretation and to highlight how different types of challenges coincide and reinforce each other. Where multiple documents or passages document the same underlying pattern within an analytical characteristic, representative examples have been selected for presentation rather than all identified instances

4.1 Inadequate economic models

Due to the length of this characteristics section, it necessitates incorporation of subtitles, this will only be used for the inadequate economic models section and is only used to ease the reading experience. The subtitles are developed from themes identified from the material.

Lack of assessment and preliminary analysis

> "The Swedish National Audit Office notes that, both prior to issuing the directive for the The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and within the framework of the negotiation itself, the state, as a negotiating party, had not assessed the transport needs of the regions it targeted."[122]

This created an important problem at the beginning of the negotiation process. The state entered negotiations without having assessed if the proposed transport measures matched the needs of the involved regions. The Swedish National Audit Office concludes that this neglect contributed to a failure to allocate effective transport investments. When this is not met, the decision support available to political actors is incomplete from the beginning and making informed prioritization difficult.

[121] Ibid. P. 36.
[122] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 31.

Inconsistencies and varying quality in cost estimates

> "The Swedish National Audit Office notes that there was varying maturity in the cost estimates that were submitted, and some projects were defined in terms of design and overall alignment during the negotiation itself. The time available to assess costs, as with other documentation, was limited." [123]

The pattern identified here in varying quality in cost estimates and projects still being defined during negotiations, shows that the inadequate economic models characteristic was not an isolated issue but a systemic feature of the project. The Swedish National Audit Office's finding that there was limited time for cost assessment links this to the unrealistic scheduling characteristic, the two reinforced each other in this way: limited time led to weaker estimates, which later shaped political commitments. Similar patterns appear in other documents reviewed for this thesis, confirming that this was a feature of the project rather than a unique problem.

Lack of standardized methods and procedures

> "The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure requested so-called successive estimates for the measures the regions wanted to negotiate. Region Stockholm was the only region that carried out this type of estimate for all the projects under consideration." [124]

The fact that only one region conformed with the requested methodology illustrates governance failure in how project managed its analytical requirements. The requested standard was successive calculation, yet we see that in practice it was applied only by Region Stockholm. This is not only a problem of inadequate economic models but also a deeper problem of implementation in the project. This case of successive estimates demonstrates what happens when this condition is not met. It's shown here that the analytical foundation becomes unequal between actors and making meaningful comparison between projects impossible. Hill and Hupe's implementation research show that progress toward shared objectives is more likely when tasks and responsibilities are clearly defined and required for every actor involved.[125]

> "The documentation that the Sweden Negotiation requested from regions and municipalities prior to the start of negotiations included a request for socio-economic analyses, but this was not followed up with requirements that resulted in such analyses being delivered. (...) Furthermore, there was essentially no description of how these benefits were to be defined or according to which methodological approach they were to be calculated. The Sweden Negotiation left it to each region and municipality to develop their own methods and approaches for assessing these benefits. The

[123] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 46.
[124] Ibid, P. 47.
[125] Hill, Hupe, 2002, P. 50.

> work was characterized partly by time constraints, and partly by a lack of clarity on how the documentation requested by the Sweden Negotiation was to be presented." [126]

This quote from the Swedish National Audit Office illustrates how the lack of standard methodological method resulted in a situation where the requested analyses were either not delivered or delivered in incomparable formats. Regions and municipalities left to develop their own methods produced material that supported local priorities instead of the nationally focused evidence needed for effective prioritisation in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. Mueller's analysis of policy failure is directly relevant. They identified the failure to account for actor reactivity as a core policy pathology, what is called the Lucas Crituiqe. When actors are given choice in how to meet requirements, they tend to adapt their behaviour to their own interests instead of the policy's original aims, and the problem lies in assuming fixed behaviour from actors.[127]

> "This compilation is based on 59 benefit assessments submitted to The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. Of these, 35 include a section labelled 'social benefits.' In the remaining cases, the term 'social benefit' may appear, but it is assessed that no clear attempt was made to calculate or evaluate this area."[128]

Having 24 of the 59 submitted assessments lacking any important analysis of social benefits is a concrete illustration of how the absence of standardization produced unreliable decision material. This connects the inadequate economic models characteristic directly to the political failure characteristic. The responsibility for creating clear definitions and methodological standards is with the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures leadership, and the failure to uphold that responsibility allowed regions and municipalities to submit incomparable material. The outcome was analytical material unable of supporting the evidence-based prioritization that governance of large-scale infrastructure requires.

The next quote is from the report Social benefits in The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure:

> "It is also clear that there is a widespread lack of expertise in this area. Nor have the consultants hired produced convincing work. The material is both quite heterogeneous and, to a large extent, a repetition of generally accepted views on sustainable urban development. This reflects the fact that Sweden does not have a well-developed tradition of describing the effects of infrastructure in social

[126] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 37.
[127] Mueller, 2020, P. 317.
[128] Winter, 2015, P. 14.

> terms. Much of the national transport planning instead adopts an instrumental view of increased accessibility as societal benefit. “ [129]

This observation adds important context to the inadequate economic models characteristic. The problem was not only that the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures failed to enforce methodological standards, but also that the analytical knowledge required to meet those standards was not generally available for the concerned actors. This displays a broad institutional gap in Swedish infrastructure planning that pre-exists the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and establishes a condition that shaped what was analytically achievable within the project’s timeframe which connects this to the external influence characteristic as well.

> “The majority of stakeholders appear to aim to place the citizen at the center of the analysis of social benefits, but the result sometimes tends to shift toward describing aggregated effects at the municipal and regional levels.” [130]

This observation from the Social benefits report illustrates conflict within the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. While actors formally committed to citizen-focused analysis, their outputs instead reflected municipal and regional priorities. This is exactly what Rhodes and Marsh’s policy network theory predicts. Networks with unequal resources and conflicting institutional interests tend to reflect those divides.[131] The move from citizen focused to regionally focused analysis was then not a failure of individual actors but a structurally expected feature of a governance arrangement where local and national priorities were never formally established.

Neglect of previous learnings and lessons not learned

> “At the same time, the cost assessments for the major projects were significantly more developed in the 2013 Stockholm Negotiation than for the Stockholm projects in the The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. Despite this better assessment, it has since become clear that these projects experienced substantial cost overruns.” [132]

This comparison between the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and the 2013 Stockholm Negotiation is noteworthy for two reasons. First it shows that the cost assessment problems represented a worsening from previous practice and not a continuation of it as the earlier as the 2013 Stockholm Negotiation project had more developed cost assessments despite covering a smaller geographic area. Second, the comment that even the more developed assessments in the 2013 Stockholm Negotiation still resulted in substantial

[129] Winter, 2015, P. 27.
[130] Winter, 2015, P. 17.
[131] Rhodes, Marsh, 1992. P. 188.
[132] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 48.

cost overruns illustrates the broader structural challenge that Flyvbjerg identifies. That cost underestimation in megaprojects is a systematic pattern that is driven by optimism bias rather than simply a matter of analytical quality.[133] Improving the quality of these assessments is necessary, but not enough. The institutional incentives that encourage strategic underestimation must instead be addressed at a fundamental level.

Strategic underestimation and optimism bias

> "According to some of those interviewed during the review, there was a desire to keep timelines short and costs low, which was perceived, among other things, as an attempt to make the costs appear more manageable in the negotiation." [134]

This is an important finding because it suggests that some actors perceived the short timelines and low costs as an attempt to make the costs appear more manageable. This is similar to what Flyvbjerg describes as strategic misrepresentation, where favourable estimates can be used to increase support for a project.[135] It also reflects Ronnle's finding that presenting optimistic figures is a core justification strategy in Swedish megaprojects.[136] The political failure characteristic is also visible here. The political pressure to present manageable costs influenced the analytical process itself, demonstrating how political incentives can damage the decision support material that is supposed to constrain political commitments.

Poor oversight and follow-up

> "The political plans are not based on a fact-based analysis of costs and benefits."[137]

This statement from Professor Maria Börjesson in response to the researchers debate article in November 2019 illustrates how the economic models were recognized and criticized by independent experts outside of the project. The statement repeats what the Swedish National Audit Office and the Transport Administration's own assessments had already showed that the analytical basis was inadequate. What makes this source notable is that it shows this criticism being raised publicly by researchers several years after the negotiation phase ended. Similar patterns of weak decision material also appear in several other documents reviewed for this characteristic. This dynamic also connects to the political failure characteristic, where political actors often continued to support the project despite external expert criticism and negative analytical findings.

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[133] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 9.
[134] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 48.
[135] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 14–15.
[136] Ronnle, 2019, P. 54–55.
[137] SVT Nyheter 2019, november 7th.

> "In light of this, I would once again like to ask the minister: Does she and the government consider this expansion to be socio-economically profitable? The calculations we have seen so far show that this is not the case."[138]

This statement from Erik Ottoson in the 2017 interpellation debate confirms that the unprofitability of the investment was recognized and raised in the Riksdag during the active negotiation phase. This is relevant to the inadequate economic models characteristic because it shows that the economic evidence was available and publicly discussed at the time political commitments were being made. The fact that an opposition politician could state in the Riksdag that existing calculations showed the investment was not socio-economically profitable without this leading to a reassessment of the project's direction is significant. The same exchange also illustrates the political failure characteristic, as the minister's response to Erik Ottoson's criticism presented later shows a political actor avoiding direct engagement with the economic evidence.

Underestimation of risk and unclear limits

> "In the national plan, it is very common for projects in early planning stages to have a cost estimate risk of 30 percent (…) the average cost estimate risk is about 16 percent. The successive estimates for the three major Stockholm projects indicated a cost risk of just under 9 percent. According to the Swedish National Audit Office, certain identified risks (so-called general conditions) were significantly reduced during an early revision of the estimates. (…) The investment costs that were agreed upon also included lower margins for cost deviations compared to the subway projects in the 2013 Stockholm Negotiation." [139]

The gap between the approximately 30 percent risk normally associated with projects in early planning stages and the just under 9 percent estimated for the three major Stockholm projects in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure provides an example of remarkably low risk margins. This also connects the inadequate economic models characteristic directly to the political failure characteristic. The reduction of risk margins below standards reflects the same political pressure to present manageable costs documented in the strategic underestimation section above. The political influence on the analytical process is visible here not through instruction but through the incentive structure that shaped how analysts handled risk assessment, which is what Mueller identifies as the reactivity pathology, where actors in a policy system adapt their behaviour in response to political incentives that undermine the policy's analytical integrity.[140]

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[138] Riksdagen (2017), anförande 73–79.
[139] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 47–48.
[140] Mueller, 2020, P. 317.

Unclear understanding and impact of analyses

> "At the same time, it is in some respects unclear what actual significance the benefit analyses had for the selection of metropolitan measures in The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. Our evaluation shows, among other things, that municipalities used different methods to calculate and assess benefits, that the analyses varied significantly in scope and content, and that the municipalities themselves felt the expectations for their benefit assessments were unclear." [141]
>
> "There was no established or clear method for calculating benefits, which led to some confusion in certain municipalities regarding the benefit assessments that the secretariat expected them to produce" [142]

This conclusion from the Swedish Agency for Public Management shows the inadequate economic models characteristic at a central stage. The lack of a standard methodological framework meant that the analytical material submitted by municipalities was not produced with a general understanding of what was being asked for. Similar findings about unclear expectations for benefit assessments were identified across other documents reviewed for this characteristic, showing that the methodological ambiguity was experienced across multiple actors and institutional levels. This echoes Hill and Hupe's view of implementation as a process of interaction in which policy can continue to be shaped during implementation. When the framework for these interactions is unclear, the resulting material reflects actors' own interpretations instead of a consistent analytical basis.[143]

Political reactions to cost overruns

The next quotes are taken from a press release from the current Swedish government where they announce a re-negotiation phase of some deals made from the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure:

> "The government has decided to appoint a negotiator to renegotiate agreements related to infrastructure projects in Stockholm." [144]

This shows a later political consequence of the cost increases. The need to renegotiate also makes the development relevant to the inadequate economic models characteristic, since earlier cost estimates developed part of the source on the agreements were made. The renegotiation process is consistent with Flyvbjerg's break-fix model. Problems that could have been addressed via adequate economic analysis during the planning phase instead required costly political involvement at a later stage.[145]

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[141] Statskontoret, 2022, P. 19.
[142] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 62.
[143] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 7–8.
[144] Regeringskansliet, 2025.
[145] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 11–12.

Political questions

The quotes below are taken from 2024 where Leif Nysmed, a Riksdag member from the Social democrats, and Linus Lakso from the environment party where they are asking, separately, the current minister Andreas Carlson about the government's commitment to the south tramway which was planned to be constructed in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure but after budget negotiation had been removed.

> "Is the minister prepared to advocate for the state to provide additional funding to make Spårväg Syd possible?" [146]

Linus Lakso from the environment party asked Minister Andreas Carlson a more general question if the government will allocate the required resources necessary in order to construct the projects in The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure.[147]
Minister Andreas Carlson answered the question by confirming that the government intends to finish their part of the agreements.[148] The characteristic inadequate economic models are exemplified by these political actors. Here is an example where not only does the inadequate economic models cause problems for the project in its work in budling measures, but it also has impact on the political sphere in the form of public confidence of these measures even being bult or the government supporting their existence in The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure.

The next two quotes are from 2021 when the previous government consisted of majority left parties and the current government was in opposition. The first quote is from Fredrik Lindahl of the Sweden Democrats, questioning Infrastructure Minister Tomas Eneroth about renegotiations between the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, the Stockholm region and several municipalities due to rising costs in decided measures.

> "What measures do the minister and the government intend to take to ensure that the costs for municipalities and regions do not become unreasonable?" [149]

These questions from Riksdag members of different parties illustrate how the inadequate economic models characteristic generated political consequences that extended beyond the project's internal governance. When cost estimates are unreliable and projects require renegotiation or additional funding, political accountability becomes a repeating demand from actors outside the project.

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[146] Skriftlig fråga 2023/24:987
[147] Ibid.
[148] Ibid
[149] Lindahl, 2021.

The material analysed in this section shows that the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure suffered from systematic problems in its economic analyses and decision-support material. These problems were not limited to individual documents or actors but formed a broader structural pattern across the project. Initial assessments were not completed before negotiations began, cost estimates varied in quality and methods across regions, standardisation rules were not enforced, risk margins were below industry standards and oversight failed to effectively track costs and benefits during implementation. These failures also reinforced one another. Limited time led to weak analyses, weak analyses produced unreliable cost estimates and unreliable cost estimates contributed to renegotiations and funding disputes documented in parliamentary questions. From the implementation research perspective this also is relevant to Pressman and Wildavsky's argument that implementation problems grow as coordination requirements increase which means that each actor in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures analytical chain that failed to provide acceptable material weakened the overall decision-making process.[150] A broader pattern also appears across the sources examined in this section. Analytical failures were identified throughout the project by actors both inside and outside and still these problems did not lead to revision. The directive expected socio-economic profitability without first commissioning the analysis needed to support it. Reports identified analytical weaknesses both during and after the negotiation phase. Maria Börjesson also stated publicly that the political plans were not based on fact-based cost–benefit analysis. Despite this, the project continued. This suggests that the inadequate economic models characteristic was not mainly due to a lack of analytical ability, since the problems were repeatedly identified, but due to governance that did not translate known problems into political correction. The Transport Administration's 2016 and 2021 findings and the directive's unsupported profitability expectations provide the clearest illustration of this pattern. These findings are discussed in the political failure section.

4.2 Conflicts between stakeholders

> "When actors such as municipalities, government agencies, or private stakeholders have conflicting goals or fail to cooperate, it can harm the project. Failing to capture local and regional perspectives can have significant consequences. (. . .) We can also conclude that the state bore responsibility in this matter. In the directives, the government stated that the negotiators should also gather input from municipalities and regions. According to The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, regional dialogues were conducted (…) However, our interviews reveal that municipalities not

[150] Pressman, Wildavsky, 1984, P. 102–107.

> designated for station locations were critical of not being given more opportunities to participate in the negotiation process.[151]

This conclusion from the Swedish Agency for Public Management is significant because it shows that responsibility for stakeholder oversight rests with both the project and the state, and not a single actor. Municipalities without station allocations felt excluded from a process that still affected their planning, despite the directive's stated aim of including regional and municipal perspectives. The state's commitment to inclusion in the directive was not supported by governance structures able to deliver it in practice. This illustrates the gap between political ambition and real outcomes. Hill and Hupe's emphasis on implementation across multiple actors and institutional levels is relevant here, where relationships between these actors form an important part of the implementation process. [152] As seen in this case, weak coordination caused uneven participation between municipalities.

> "We are in a situation where we have based our actions on agreements and planning that we believed were settled with the state. Right now, everything is on shaky ground. We're simply trying to navigate correctly and provide the state with the information they need. And stand our ground. That's what we need to do in this situation." [153]

This quote from a local official after the state's unexpected announcement of renegotiations shows the consequences of stakeholder misalignment. When one actor in a multi-actor process changes position without proper communication, the cooperative structure based on shared agreements becomes unstable. Mueller's implementation research is relevant here. They identify failure to account for actor reactivity as a key policy problem. When the state changed its position on agreed measures, local actors adjusted their behaviour to protect their own interests instead of supporting the project's goals.[154] This shows how a breakdown in communication between levels can spread and weaken the trust needed for multi-actor implementation.

The 2017 interpellation debate also documents the political divisions surrounding the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure at the national level. The exchange between opposition and government shows politicians with fundamentally different positions on the project's economic basis as the opposition pointing out profitability concerns that the then government dismissed as irrelevant to political judgment. This divide is relevant to the

[151] Statskontoret, 2022, P. 57.
[152] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 14–16.
[153] Mitt i, 2021.
[154] Mueller, 2020, P. 317.

conflicts between stakeholder's characteristic because it illustrates how political disagreement at the national level created an unstable environment for a project that needed continued support across political parties to succeed. McConnell identifies that a policy that fails to garner support from key stakeholders, including opposition parties who may form government in the future, has a structural weakness in its political sustainability.[155] The same debate exchange is also used in the political failure characteristic, because it shows how the minister responded to economic evidence, and in the inadequate economic models characteristic, because it reflects the quality of the economic evidence during the negotiation phase. Its relevance here is the partisan dimension: the project's political basis was contested and not widely shared across parties from the early stage.

The material in this section indicates that conflicts between stakeholders were a recurring and expected element of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and not just isolated disagreements. Municipalities felt excluded from negotiations, stakeholders often prioritized local and regional interests over national goals and unexpected changes in the state's position damaged the trust needed for multi-actor implementation. These conflicts were not accidental, but predictable within a policy network where actors had unequal resources, different interests and uneven access to decision-making, without effective mechanisms for resolving those differences. The findings connect to the political failure characteristic, where unclear leadership and unclear definitions allowed competing interests to continue unresolved, and to the external influence characteristic, where the co-financing model shaped stakeholder behaviour in ways that differed from the project's stated goals. A larger pattern appears when taking the sources together. Stakeholder conflicts occurred at every institutional level at the same time. At the national level, the interpellation debate showed strong disagreement between government and opposition over the project's economic reasoning. At the regional level, the Swedish Agency for Public Management evaluation showed municipalities prioritising local interests over national goals. At the project level, Mitt i Stockholm reported that local officials discovered established agreements were being renegotiated without warning. What is analytically important is that these conflicts were not simply spreading down from the national level to the local level. They happened simultaneously across all levels. This suggests that the stakeholder conflict characteristic

[155] McConnell, 2015, P. 227.

reflected not a single governance failure, but a broader lack of a shared framework across all institutional levels involved in the project.

4.3 External influence

> "The risk of suboptimal investment choices increases if there are no clear principles for how the negotiation should be conducted. The incentive structure in co-financing negotiations tends to favor outcomes that differ from the ambitions expressed by the Parliament in the national transport policy goals. The parties may perceive the negotiated measures as being subsidized compared to other possible measures, since the costs are shared. There is also a risk of weaker cost control, as the interests of the negotiating parties may lead to cost-effective solutions to existing traffic problems—such as cheaper reconstruction measures or traffic-reducing interventions—not being sufficiently considered." [156]

This review from the Swedish National Audit Office identifies a central problem in how the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures co-financing model influenced actor behaviour. The model, which was designed to incentivize new investment by sharing costs between the state and local actors, instead resulted in a dynamic where parties treated measures as subsidized rather than as cost-effective solutions to real transport needs. This is a clear illustration of Mueller's reactivity pathology. The co-financing model changed how actors calculated their interests, leading to behaviour that consistently differed from the national transport policy goals it was meant to support.[157] The incentive structure acted as an external influence on the project's outcomes because its effects were accidental and worked independently of the project's goals. It reshaped priorities and limited the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures leadership control.

> "Municipal representatives who participated in the negotiation pointed out that the housing commitments largely involved already planned housing—projects that had been 'in the drawer' beforehand. The representatives noted that some of these housing developments required improved public transport to achieve an acceptable traffic situation, but that they likely would have been built even if the negotiation had not been based on housing as a counter-performance. Several of the larger developments near public transport had been planned before The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure began."[158]

This statement demonstrates how established conditions outside the projects control shaped its negotiation outcomes despite of its actions. The housing commitments that were supposed to represent new value generated by the co-financing model were in several cases existing plans

[156] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 19–20.
[157] Mueller, 2020. P. 317.
[158] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 41.

that municipalities submitted because the incentive structure made it the rational choice. From an implementation perspective Hill and Hupe emphasise that implementation outcomes are modelled by the wider institutional and external context a policy operates in.[159] In this case, previously planned housing formed part of this context and influenced the outcomes attributed to the project. The co-financing model's failure to distinguish between new housing commitments and already planned developments meant its main goal of creating additional housing was weakened from the start. This links directly to Mueller's argument about policy complexity. Policies in complex institutional settings are shaped by factors that exist before and outside the policy itself, and that cannot be controlled through internal governance alone.[160]

This section shows that external influences shaped the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures outcomes in two main ways. First the co-financing model promoted behaviour that differed from national transport policy goals, rewarding subsidy-seeking and not cost-effective investment. At the same time, many housing commitments already existed before the project started meaning that some housing goals would likely have been completed even without the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. This weakened the impact that the co-financing model was intended to have. Together, these findings show that outcomes are shaped both by incentives within the project and by the external environment it operates in, factors that are difficult to control through internal governance alone. They also link to the conflicts between stakeholder's characteristic, where the co-financing model encouraged actors to prioritise their own interests over shared goals, and to the political failure characteristic, where unclear negotiation standards allowed these incentive dynamics to continue. A wider pattern also develops across the material in this section. Many of the external influences identified were predictable. The subsidy-seeking behaviour created by the co-financing model was a structural consequence of cost-sharing measures already identified by the Swedish National Audit Office. Existing municipal housing plans were also known before negotiations began. Political instability across election cycles was a predictable challenge for a project that lacked broad cross-party support. Broadly, the material suggests that the external influence characteristic involved fewer genuinely external disruptions than the term indicates. Many of the problems were unintended consequences of early design choices, which the leadership had both the opportunity and responsibility to anticipate. This moves the explanation away from

[159] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 181–183.
[160] Mueller, 2020, P. 314.

uncontrollable external factors toward avoidable governance design failures, linking this characteristic back to the political failure characteristic.

4.4 Unrealistic scheduling

SOU 2017:107 documents what the 2014–2017 mandate period required in practice, financing proposals, stakeholder negotiations across multiple rail corridors, housing agreements and station placements, all running simultaneously within three years.[161] This provides context for why the cost estimates were produced under difficult conditions and why their quality could be affected by the limited timeframe. The same description also illustrates the conflicts between stakeholders characteristic. Reaching simultaneous agreements with municipalities and regions across multiple rail corridors, each with different local priorities and institutional resources is what Rhodes and Marsh identify as structurally creating coordination challenges, where unequal resources and diverging interests make conflict a predictable feature rather than an unique outcome.[162] This account of the mandate period in practice illustrates how the scheduling pressure documented above manifested concretely in the negotiation process.

> The mandate of the The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure was exceptionally extensive and was to be completed within a relatively tight timeframe. (…) The scope of the measures included in the negotiation mandate came to roughly equal the total value of all investments in the national transport plan for 2018–2029. This assignment was to be managed by a secretariat consisting of about a dozen staff members. [163]

This observation from the Swedish National Audit Office highlights the circumstances the project operated in from the start. Compared with the total value of the national transport plan, it clearly shows the scale of the mandate and makes the unrealistic scheduling characteristic clear. A small secretariat of around twelve staff members was responsible for a negotiation mandate whose measures were roughly equal in value to all investments in the national transport plan from 2018 to 2029. This is in alignment with the importance Hill and Hupe puts on sufficient time and resources as conditions for implementation. When the resources allocated to a policy process are misaligned with the complexity of the task, implementation deficits become expected regardless of the quality of individual decisions made within the process.[164] This also links directly to Dir. 2014:106. The conditions identified by the Swedish National Audit Office were established when the directive was issued, showing that unrealistic scheduling was rooted in the project's design before implementation began.

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[161] SOU 2017:107, P. 41–44.
[162] SOU 2017:107, P. 147-148, 150-151. Rhodes, Marsh, 1992, P. 188.
[163] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 28.
[164] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P.50.

> "An example of insufficient state oversight and control prior to construction start is the cable car project in Gothenburg, which was initially estimated to cost SEK 1.1 billion (. . .) A revised cost estimate later placed the cost at approximately SEK 4 billion, which rendered the project highly unprofitable according to the assessment. In the autumn of 2020, renegotiations began between the state, the region and the municipality on how the project could be removed and how the associated housing commitments should be adjusted."[165]

The Gothenburg cable car project shows how inadequate early cost assessment and oversight could later create implementation problems. The estimated cost increased from SEK 1.1 billion to approximately SEK 4 billion, which made the project extremely unprofitable and led to renegotiation. This example links the inadequate economic models characteristic to later governance and implementation problems. This example is relevant to unrealistic scheduling when reflected together with the other findings in this section which shows that limited time lowered the quality of assessments produced during the negotiation. This is consistent with Flyvbjerg's break-fix model where failures inadequately addressed in early project stages generate significantly higher costs when they surface later.[166] The decision to cancel the measure instead of accepting the revised costs reflects a broader pattern identified in this thesis: the effects of unrealistic scheduling were not limited to timing, but also spread across economic, governance and stakeholder dimensions.

> "Our conclusion is that the metropolitan agreements of The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure had an overly optimistic timeline, which contributed to the fact that the analyses and documentation prepared by municipalities and regions were, in some respects, not of sufficient quality to serve as a basis for the negotiation. Although municipalities later supplemented their submissions, the analyses remained incomplete during the negotiation phase. There is therefore a risk that the documentation was not sufficient to determine which measures were effective and to prioritize among them. We assess that this could partly have been avoided if the negotiations had been given more time." [167]

This conclusion from the Swedish Agency for Public Management is the clearest assessment in the material of the effects of unrealistic scheduling. It shows that weak documentation resulted directly from limited time, linking the unrealistic scheduling characteristic to the inadequate economic model characteristic. The two reinforced each other: time pressure led to weaker analysis, which in turn weakened the project's decision-making basis. Hill and Hupe's review of implementation research highlight that adequate time and resources are vital for

[165] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 57.
[166] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 11–12.
[167] Statskontoret, 2022, P. 19.

successful policy implementation and is confirmed by this evidence. The lack of time produced the coordination and implementation problems they identify as the predictable consequence of inadequate timeframes.[168] The Swedish Agency for Public Management's conclusion that the outcome could partially have been avoided with more time shows a direct acknowledgment from an evaluating agency that the scheduling environment were a main driver of the analytical failures documented throughout this thesis.

The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure operated under an unrealistically ambitious timeline that was established through Dir. 2014:106. The tight schedule forced municipalities and regions to produce analyses under intense time pressure which resulted in incomplete and incomparable material that could not support the prioritization decisions required during the negotiations. Unrealistic scheduling acted as a structural condition that amplified the effects of the other characteristics, producing the inadequate economic models, contributing to stakeholder conflicts caused by rushed and incomplete discussions and creating political pressures that led to renegotiations and cancellations. The findings connect directly to the inadequate economic models characteristic that the tight timeline created analytical weaknesses and to the political failure characteristic where timelines were set without sufficient consideration of the practical demands of multi-actor infrastructure implementation. Unrealistic scheduling acted as a reinforcing element for all the other characteristics identified in this thesis. The directive created the timeline, the final report showed what was required in practice to fit the process into that timeline and the Swedish National Audit Office and Statskontoret documented effects on analytical quality, stakeholder engagement and governance outcomes. The material shows that the timeline was too short for the type of multi-actor governance the project required. It depended on broad stakeholder input, comparable data from different regions and a consolidated socio-economic analysis before political commitments. The schedule made all of these difficult to achieve at once. This suggests the problem was not only poor timing, but a deeper difference between the directive's ambitions and the governance reality of the project.

4.5 Political failure

The government directive issued in July 2014 created the formal mandate for the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and marks the starting point for understanding the

[168] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 50

project's early conditions. The directive gave a negotiator a broad set of objectives to complete within a three-year period from 2014 to 2017. These included developing financing principles and plans for new high-speed rail between Stockholm, Gothenburg and Malmö, negotiating station locations with municipalities and regions, reaching housing agreements along the planned routes and investigating rail expansion in northern Sweden through corporate and municipal co-financing.[169] The large scale of this government mandate is directly relevant to the unrealistic scheduling characteristic. The directive established a timeline that required going from an undefined planning phase to concluded negotiations and a final report within three years, while covering a geographic scale and institutional complexity that Flyvbjerg's research would characterize as systematically underestimating the practical demands of implementation.[170]

The directive's objectives are also relevant to the inadequate economic models characteristic. The mandate states that the purpose of the negotiation is to allow a fast implementation of high-speed rail in a way that maximizes socio-economic profitability, and to also identify cost-effective measures leading to improved accessibility and increased housing construction.[171] The focus on maximizing socio-economic profitability is also notable in hindsight: both the 2016 and 2021 Swedish Transport Administration analyses later found the investment to be unprofitable, even though the directive set this goal without a prior economic analysis to support it. The directive established that there was expectations of profitability but without providing a consolidated economic analysis as a basis for negotiations, which is consistent with the Swedish National Audit Office's future finding that the state had not evaluated the transport needs of the regions before issuing the directive.[172] This lack of initial economic analysis at the mandate stage exhibits a weakness in the decision support available from the beginning of the project. The political failure characteristic is also present in the directive. The mandate was issued without a unified socio-economic assessment of the proposed investment. At the same time, the directive's timeline 2014–2017 reflected political expectations of fast progress that did not account for the known practical demands of large-scale infrastructure planning. Path dependency suggest that the political commitments established at this early stage, with the objective of building Sweden's first high-speed railway as soon as possible would have created a self-reinforcing path that would make later path change based on reassessment increasingly

[169] Dir. 2014:106, P. 1.
[170] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 14–15.
[171] Dir. 2014:106, P. 1
[172] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 31.

costly, even as later analyses showed that the project's economic justification was not supported by the existing evidence.[173] The directive represents not only the formal starting point of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure but also the critical juncture where the conditions for later political failure were established.

The directive's description of the negotiator's role clearly shows the conflicts between stakeholder's characteristics. By requiring the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure to reach agreements with municipalities and regions across different areas while also balancing national transport goals and a tight timeline.[174] Rhodes and Marsh's policy network theory explains that a situation where a central government negotiator must align actors with unequal resources and different local and national interests means that coordination challenges are a an expected governance outcome of the project instead of an unintended failure.[175] The directive failed to establish a framework for resolving conflicts between local/regional priorities and national goals. And as the project progressed this lack of direction became a source of conflict in the actual negotiations. The analysis of this directive shows that the failure characteristics identified in this thesis were present from the start and already rooted in the project's foundational document. The directive set an overly ambitious timeline, gave a single negotiator a very broad mandate, required socio-economic profitability without prior analysis and created a multi-actor structure without clear mechanisms for resolving conflicts. These findings are consistent with Hill and Hupe's review of implementation conditions on adequate time and resources, clear objectives and coordination between actors.[176] The material does not show a project that gradually declined but predictable effects of a mandate that was poorly designed for its project. These early governance conditions which were established before implementation had begun, directly shaped the patterns of political failure documented throughout this section of the thesis.

> "We observe that the sum of effects corresponds to slightly more than one third of the total investment cost and that the net present value amounts to approximately −253 billion SEK under the current discounting principles. The net present value ratio is −0.6, and the investment can therefore be assessed as highly unprofitable."[177]

The 2016 Swedish Transport Administration assessment is important as it shows how negative socio-economic findings related to political decision-making. The Swedish Transport

[173] Pierson, 2000, P. 252–253.
[174] Dir. 2014:106, P. 1–2.
[175] Rhodes, Marsh, 1992. P. 188.
[176] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 50.
[177] Trafikverket, 2016, P. 55

Administrations explicit conclusion that the investment is "highly unprofitable" shows a clear expert assessment with relevance for political decision making. The calculations show an important point of comparison. The 2016 analysis was produced internally of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and during its negotiation phase. It covered the most comprehensive estimates available at that stage and applied cost benefit principles to assess the economic effects of the high-speed rail investment. While the calculations formed part of the negotiation process in 2016, it was not a comprehensive evaluation. The 2016 analysis was a socio-economic profitability assessment of the proposed high-speed rail system using Trafikverket's standard appraisal framework. It included the main direct socio-economic effects normally included in transport appraisal, while the report also acknowledged uncertainties and effects that were not included in the standard calculation. According to the 2016 report, the calculations were based on preliminary technical documentation and "standard cost calculation" for several critical cost components, which led to significant uncertainties in the total investment assessment.[178]

Effect category	**Net present value (SEK million)**	**Assessment**
Net present value (NPV) – main analysis	–302,356 million SEK	Negative overall result
Benefit–cost assessment	NPV < 0	Socio-economically unprofitable
Sensitivity analysis: higher investment costs	–440,498 million SEK	Result remains negative
Sensitivity analysis: traffic growth +50%	–244,985 million SEK	Result remains negative
Overall socio-economic assessment	Unprofitable	Conclusion unchanged across scenarios

Table 2

Source: Author's selection and translation based on Trafikverket (2021), Only outcome indicators relevant to the analytical focus are included. The full original table is found in Appendix A.

Table 2 summarises the key findings from the 2021 assessment, confirming the pattern of socio-economic unprofitability across tested scenarios. The increased costs and benefits from the analysis show that the infrastructure measure fails to reach economic viability primarily due to substantial costs that exceed the estimated societal gains. While benefits such as travel time savings and increased accessibility contribute positively, these gains are outweighed by high investment costs and limited monetised returns, resulting in a negative net value across the main and sensitivity scenarios. The Swedish Transport Administrations own assessment characterises the project as societally unprofitable, as can be seen from table 2. Table 2 illustrates political

[178] Trafikverket, 2016, P. 7. 11

failure clearly. Despite the Swedish Transport Administration's 2021 conclusion that the investment was societally unprofitable, the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure continued without major re-examination or renegotiation. This shows a disconnect between expert analysis and political action.

It is important to emphasise that the 2021 position paper does not in itself represent political failure within the analytical framework applied in this thesis. The analysis was completed several years after the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure had formally concluded its negotiations, when major political commitments had already been made. This limited its ability to influence political decisions. The issue is not the existence of the 2021 assessment, but the timing and institutional context in which it was produced. The 2016 calculation is different because it was available during the negotiation phase. However, the author of this thesis could not identify any documentation showing that its results led to major revisions of the project or reconsideration of the negotiated agreements. The 2024 Government Communication on the National Audit Office's report similarly notes problems with reassessing infrastructure investments when costs and assumptions change.[179] This pattern is consistent with Pierson's argument that earlier political commitments can become increasingly difficult to reverse over time.[180] The 2016 analysis also shows evidence for the Inadequate economic models characteristic. As reported by the Swedish National Audit Office, The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure progressed without a sufficiently holistic socio-economic evaluation during the negotiation phase, indicating that the 2016 analysis did not provide a full decision support analysis typically required for large-scale infrastructure projects.[181] It is important to note that the 2016 analysis was conducted in line with conventional assessment practices and does not display methodological errors. Rather, its limitation lies in the analysis scope, the issue is not the incorrect use of economic models, but the lack of a holistic assessment.

The final report written by the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures own negotiators in December 2017 gives an inside perspective on the project. This makes it analytically valuable specifically because it documents how the project's negotiators understood and described its own situation which includes acknowledgement of the projects economic problems while continuing to support the project. The political failure characteristic

[179] Regeringskansliet, 2024, P. 4.
[180] Pierson, 2000, P. 252–253.
[181] Riksrevisionen 2021. P. 4–5.

is shown in the report's management of the socio-economic assessment. The negotiators examine the Transport Administration's 2016 cost-benefit findings and responded by presenting alternative analytical perspectives and broader socio-economic arguments which are in favour of the project.[182] This thesis does not treat the 2016 Transport Administration's assessment as inherently correct simply because it is negative. Its analytical significance lies instead in the pattern it reveals across two independent sources. The 2016 Transport Administration analysis, produced within the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure during the negotiation phase, already indicated that the investment was not socio-economically profitable. The 2021 Transport Administration position paper, produced after the final report had been submitted, confirmed this finding. It is important to note that the negotiators could only have responded to the 2016 assessment as the 2021 position paper did not exist at the time SOU 2017:107 was submitted. The 2021 analysis is therefore not part of what the negotiators responded to but confirms that the same pattern of unprofitability persisted after the project's formal negotiation phase had ended.

The Swedish National Audit Office identified a flaw in how the city contracts were negotiated: the process moved forward without a full socio-economic evaluation as the basis for the agreements.[183] This means there were two problems: completed analyses showed the project was unprofitable and the analytical basis that should have guided the negotiations was never in place. The 2016 assessment was even tough met with alternate analyses that framed the investment more positively which is a pattern that Ronnle describes as a common justification strategy, where negative cost–benefit findings are countered with alternative estimates instead of reconsideration.[184] The significance of this passage is in exhibiting that the project's leadership recognized the negative socio-economic findings but still chose to continue on with this project over reassessing it. This thesis identifies this specific response as a clear instance of political failure. The negotiators report provides evidence of this pattern occurring internally in the project, which is also reinforcing the political failure characteristic identified through the Transport Administration analyses above. Both analyses together provide central empirical evidence of political failure in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure.

[182] SOU 2017:107, P 90-91.
[183] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 4–5.
[184] Ronnle, 2019, P.54–55.

> "This reflects the fact that Sweden does not have a well-developed tradition of describing the effects of infrastructure in social terms. Much of the national transport planning instead adopts an instrumental view of increased accessibility as societal benefit." [185]

This observation from the social benefits report points to a political failure that existed before the project was created. The lack of a standard way to assess infrastructure effects in social terms was not a failure of the project itself, but an institutional gap in Swedish infrastructure planning that had not been addressed earlier in the political system. From an implementation perspective, Hill and Hupe emphasise that implementation is shaped by the institutional context in which a policy operates.[186] The lack of an established method for assessing social benefits limited what could be achieved within the project. This finding also links to the external influence characteristic, the gap in Swedish planning practise worked as an external condition that shaped what could realistically be achieved within the project's timeframe.

> "In several cases, the regions chose to submit a large number of potential measures to The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure that aligned with the communicated selection criteria. This was because, in many instances, they had not yet finalized their own internal political priorities, or because it was unclear which measure had the greatest chance of receiving co-financing." [187]

This finding shows how incomplete regional political prioritisation added to the governance challenges. Regions that had not established their internal priorities responded to the project's unclear criteria by submitting large amounts of measures rather than certain analytically proposals. As a result of this, the negotiation process was filled with quantity over quality. The unclear national criteria and unclear regional political priorities produced a self-reinforcing effect where neither of the actors involved was able to ensure the analytical level the process demanded. Pierson's path dependency logic is relevant because these early uncertainties shaped later decisions and made it increasingly difficult for actors to change direction once the process had developed.

> "Interviews also reveal that municipal and regional processes are often more closely tied to politics, which can lead to priorities that differ from those that are objectively the most effective. Furthermore, regions and municipalities have a legitimate interest in implementing measures that benefit residents in their own area—interests that do not necessarily align with the most effective solution from a national perspective." [188]

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[185] Winter, 2015, P. 27.
[186] Hill, Hupe, 2002. P. 181–183.
[187] Riksrevisionen, 2021, P. 33.
[188] Ibid. P. 33.

This observation from the Swedish National Audit Office highlights a fundamental tension in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures design. The project required local actors to produce analysis for national goals, even though they operate within systems focused on local priorities. Rhodes and Marsh's policy network theory sees this tension as expected. In networks with unequal power and opposing interests, local priorities naturally compete with national objectives.[189] The political failure characteristic is visible here not as abnormal behaviour, but as a predictable result of a governance design that did not consider the incentives shaping how local political actors contributed to the analytical process.

> "The announcement about the renegotiations came as a complete surprise to the municipality. Municipal Director Victor Kilén diplomatically states that he would have appreciated a heads-up about what was going on." [190]

The state's decision to announce renegotiations without first informing the affected municipalities reflects a broader pattern of top-down decision-making that did not treat local actors as partners in the implementation process. From an implementation research perspective this reflects what Pressman and Wildavsky identify as a critical source of implementation failure. Actors who depend on each other for successful implementation are not kept informed of decisions that affect their planning conditions.[191] McConnell's policy failure definition is also relevant here. When major decisions are made without transparency or adequate stakeholder involvement, the support needed to sustain a policy during implementation is gradually weakened.[192]

> "The question of whether I think it is socio-economically profitable is rather uninteresting — it is not a matter one can have opinions about."

This statement from Infrastructure Minister Anna Johansson in the 2017 interpellation debate is important because it shows how the government responded to the negative socio-economic assessment during the active negotiation phase. Johansson acknowledged that the existing calculation models showed the investment to be socio-economically unprofitable but argued that the political assessment also had to consider other factors, including capacity needs, regional development and housing. The statement illustrates a gap between the result of the economic analysis and the bigger considerations used to justify continued political support. This is relevant to the political failure characteristic because socio-economic profitability was a clear objective of the directive while the political decision-making process relied on a broader set of

[189] Rhodes, Marsh, 1992, P. 188.
[190] Mitt i, 2021.
[191] Pressman, Wildavsky, 1984, P. 102–107.
[192] McConnell, 2015, P. 227.

objectives when the economic assessment was negative. It is also relevant to path dependency, as continued political commitment increasingly became supported by arguments beyond the project's original economic objective.[193]

> "This is about modernising the entire Swedish infrastructure and meeting climate targets. In that case, it is not sufficient to discuss a slow transition of road transport."[194]

The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructures mandate stated its purpose: "The purpose of the negotiator is, in part, to enable the rapid implementation of high-speed rail in a way that maximizes its socio-economic profitability…"[195] The project was explicitly required to maximize socio-economic profitability. However, when confronted with researchers' economic criticism in a television debate in November 2019, Infrastructure Minister Tomas Eneroth did not directly address the profitability arguments. He instead shifted the discussion toward climate and modernization: "This is about modernising the entire Swedish infrastructure and meeting climate targets."[196] This redirecting away from economic evidence was also present in the previous quote from Anna Johansson in 2017. Taken together, these three statements show that the gap between political reasoning and the project's stated economic objectives was not a one-time decision, but a repeated pattern across different governments. This is consistent with what Ronnle identifies as a core justification strategy in megaprojects. When cost-benefit analyses show unfavourable results, project advocates shift to alternative narratives instead of addressing the economic critique on its own terms.[197] It also demonstrates Pierson's path dependency as the political justification increasingly relied upon objectives outside socio-economic profitability as commitments to the project continued over time.[198]

An exchange between Infrastructure Minister Eneroth and Professor Börjesson in November 2019 also illustrates the external influence characteristic: Two years after the final report was submitted, the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure was still politically active despite ongoing expert criticism of its economic situation. The minister's defence of the project on climate and not on economic grounds reflects a broader shift in the political narrative over time, driven more by changing policy priorities, such as climate policy, than by the project's own analysis. This mirrors Mueller's argument that policies develop together

[193] Pierson, 2000, P. 252–253.
[194] SVT Nyheter. 2019b.
[195] Dir. 2014:106 P. 1.
[196] SVT Nyheter. 2019
[197] Ronnle, 2019, P. 54–55.
[198] Pierson, 2000, P. 252-253.

with their political and institutional environment, with the project's justification shifting to match the most relevant external political priority at the time instead of staying fixed to its original analytical foundation.[199] The same quote is thus relevant to both the political failure characteristic where it documents the pattern of redirecting from economic evidence and to the external influence characteristic where it shows how shifting external political circumstances shaped how the project was justified and sustained over time.

The material in this section shows that political failure appeared across several parts within the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. A central finding was that economic evidence had limited influence on political commitments. Dir. 2014:106 set socio-economic profitability as an objective before a consolidated economic basis was in place, while the 2016 assessment found the high-speed rail investment to be highly unprofitable. SOU 2017:107 responded to this assessment by presenting broader arguments in support of the project, while the 2021 assessment later showed that the profitability problem remained. This shows that political failure was connected to decisions made early in the project and continued through to later stages of implementation**.** The lack of established definitions for social benefits showed an institutional gap that political leadership had not addressed. Regional political instability led to insufficient analyses that prioritized quantity over quality. The gap between local political incentives and national objectives created competing priorities. The state's failure to communicate major decisions clearly to municipal actors weakened the trust needed for multi-actor implementation. The findings in this section also connects to all the other four characteristics. Political failure created the conditions were inadequate economic models went accepted, stakeholder conflicts went unresolved, external incentive structures were not addressed and unrealistic scheduling expectations continued despite evidence that they were unrealistic. Political failure worked on two connected levels. At the national level, ministers in the Riksdag downplayed socio-economic profitability, with Anna Johansson in 2017 and Tomas Eneroth in 2019, even though final report identified it as a key objective. At the regional and local level, actors produced weak and inconsistent analytical material due to limited incentives to do otherwise. National disregard for economic evidence reduced incentives for strong local analysis, while weak local analysis limited the information available to national decision-makers. Together these dynamics reinforced each other and contributed to the gap between stated objectives and actual outcomes described in this thesis.

[199] Mueller, 2020, P. 314.

5. Conclusion and discussion

This chapter brings together the findings of the thesis and answers the three research questions. Since the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure is still ongoing the findings reflect its development up to 2025.

5.1 Overall Conclusion

The main conclusion of this thesis is that the implementation problems of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure cannot be understood through one analytical characteristic alone. The five characteristics were established as analytical categories before the empirical analysis and should not be understood as findings that emerged from the material. The thesis contribution is in showing how problems within these characteristics were manifested and reinforced each other mainly in weaknesses in the project's governance design.

5.2 Manifestation and Interaction of the Five Analytical Characteristics

The first research question asks: How are the five analytical failure characteristics manifested in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, and how do they interact to shape the project's outcomes? The empirical material showed that all five analytical characteristics was manifested in the case, but the most important finding is that the problems identified did not operate separately. The first characteristic concerned inadequate economic models and decision-support material. The analysis showed that important assessments had not been completed before the negotiations started. Cost estimates varied in quality, methodological standards were not consistent, and municipalities and regions were frequently left to develop their own methods in order to measure benefits. This produced material that was difficult to compare and at times focused on local priorities instead of national priorities. These weaknesses were connected to unrealistic scheduling. The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure was given a large mandate that included financing, negotiations with municipalities and regions, housing agreements, station locations and planning for high-speed rail. These responsibilities were also given a timeline of nearly three years. That an office of approximately twelve people managed a task equal in financial scale to the entire national transport plan as noted by the Swedish National Audit Office clearly highlights the difference between the mandate's scale and the administrative resources available. The limited timeframe hurt the quality of the analyses produced by municipalities and regions. Projects and cost estimates were still being created during the negotiations while political

commitments were made before the analytical material was complete. Unrealistic scheduling contributed to inadequate economic models since the limited timeframe did not allow the essential analyses to be completed before they were used in negotiations.

The inadequate analysis also contributed to conflicts between stakeholders. The state, regions and municipalities had different responsibilities and political priorities but still relied on each other to forward the project and their intentions and objectives did not always align with each other. The lack of an established methodological methods exaggerated these conflicts. When regions and municipalities were allowed to develop their own methods and submit large numbers of proposals, they had incentives to prioritise their own local interests. The lack of a clear national standard contributed to inconsistent material, inadequate work, unequal participation and priority differences. External influence also shaped the project but the difference between external conditions and internal governance was ambiguous. The co-financing model influenced actor incentives, while some housing commitments involved plans that already existed before the negotiation. This led to actors could have benefited from presenting existing plans as new commitments created through the project when in reality they were not. Changes in political priorities over time also impacted how the project was justified and renegotiated. The findings show that external conditions and the project's governance design sometimes overlapped in shaping its outcomes. Political failure also connected the other characteristics to each other. The material showed that political actors continued to support the project despite significant financial concerns. The Swedish Transport Administration's analyses in 2016 and 2021 together with criticism from independent researchers, did not lead to political reassessment of the direction of the project. Political responses instead shifted toward arguments on climate, modernization, housing and regional development. Political failure was also visible in the lack of clear standards and follow-up mechanisms. The project leadership did not make sure regions and municipalities used comparable methods and weak material was accepted. The political level gave a large mandate and timetable but did not create sufficient mechanisms for correcting the problems that followed.

Overall, the characteristics reinforced each other. Limited time weakened the analytical material, which made political and economic commitments less reliable. Unclear standards and incentive structures increased stakeholder conflict, while continued political commitment reduced the likelihood that these problems would lead to an early reassessment. Later

renegotiations created more uncertainty for municipalities and regions. The answer to the first research question is therefore that all five analytical characteristics were manifested in the case, but their significance is mainly in how the problems within them reinforced one another. Unrealistic scheduling and political failure played a central role in characteristic interactions as they allowed weaknesses in the other areas to develop without being fixed.

5.3 Explaining the Findings Through the Theoretical Framework

The second research question asks: How can the identified failures be explained through path dependency, policy network theory and implementation research? The three perspectives are used as complementary explanations of different parts of the same governance process.
Path dependency explains why political commitment became increasingly difficult to reverse. Dir. 2014:106 established objectives and commitments which municipalities, regions, agencies and political actors began to plan around for. When these commitments were reinforced through negotiations, reports and agreements, changing direction became increasingly costly, which helps explain why negative economic assessments did not lead to reassessment of the project.[200] The ministerial statements from 2017 and 2019 also show how the political justification shifted toward capacity, housing, climate and modernization as the economic justification became weaker. This pattern is consistent with Ronnle's findings on how broader objectives were used to maintain support for the Swedish high-speed rail project despite negative cost-benefit results.[201]

Policy network theory explains why stakeholder conflicts were a recurring part of the project and not just isolated disagreements. The state, municipalities, regions and agencies controlled different resources and had different objectives, while depending on each other for implementation. These differences created conditions for recurring conflict and coordination problems.[202] The co-financing model also changed actor incentives by encouraging municipalities and regions to adjust their proposals in order to get available funding opportunities. This reflects Mueller's argument that actors can change their behaviour in response to the incentives created by a policy, which then can change how the policy works in practice.[203]

[200] Mahoney, 2000, P. 511-513. Pierson, 2000, P. 252–253.
[201] Ronnle, 2019, P. 55–57.
[202] Rhodes & Marsh, 1992, P. 182.186-188.
[203] Mueller, 2020, P. 317.

Implementation research helps explain how these conditions produced a gap between political objectives and actual outcomes. The project required coordination between actors and decisions while important analyses and agreements were developed under in a short time schedule. This increased the risk of delays, conflicts and changes during implementation which reflects Pressman and Wildavsky's argument about the problems created by multiple clearance points.[204] Hill and Hupe's view of policy formation continuing during implementation is also relevant here as important parts of the project were still being defined while actors were already expected to implement them.[205] Mueller's complexity perspective also helps explain why problems within one characteristic affected problems in the others.[206]

The answer to the second research question is that the three theoretical perspectives explain different parts of the governance problems identified in the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, while taken together they show how these problems were connected. Path dependency explains why the political direction became increasingly difficult to change, policy network theory explains recurring conflicts and coordination problems between actors, and implementation research explains how high coordination demands, limited time and changes during the process contributed to further implementation problems. Together, they show how weaknesses in the original governance design developed into later implementation problems.

5.4 Recommendations for Future Swedish Megaprojects

The third research question: Based on the findings from the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure, what recommendations can be presented to improve the planning and implementation of future Swedish megaprojects?

The first recommendation is that analytical requirements should be established before political and binding commitments are made. Future projects should begin with clear and through assessments of transport needs, expected costs, benefits and risks. The same methodological standards should apply to all actors, and the definitions of benefits should be established at the start of the project. Independent review of major analytical documents could help improve quality before agreements are made. Analytical requirements must be clearly defined and consistently applied. Updated analyses need to also have a formal role in the political

[204] Pressman & Wildavsky, 1984, P. 102–107.
[205] Hill & Hupe, 2002, P. 7–8.
[206] Mueller, 2020, P. 314.

decision-making process. Future governance structures should include mandatory review points where major changes in costs, risks or benefits trigger a reassessment of the project and its political commitments. Political actors should also be required to explain why they continue to support a project when independent assessments challenge its main assumptions.

The second recommendation is that project schedules need to reflect the actual requirements of multi-actor governance. Political ambition should not determine the timeframe without considering the number of actors, required analyses and institutional decisions involved. Analytical work also must be completed before negotiations create binding commitments. The project organization should have sufficient staff, and expertise and independent reviews can help make sure schedules and staffing are realistic.

The third recommendation has to do with stakeholder coordination. Future projects should define the roles and responsibilities of the state, regions, municipalities and agencies before negotiations begin. Actors should know what information they are expected to provide, which methods they use and how disagreements will be solved. This is particularly important when actors have different institutional responsibilities and unequal access to financing or decision-making. The effects of co-financing models on actor behaviour should also be considered before they are introduced.

The fourth recommendation is that long-term megaprojects should have clear processes for maintaining continuity when governments and political priorities change. Main objectives and evaluation criteria should be clearly documented. If the justification or purpose of a project changes significantly, the objectives should be formally revised and the project reassessed. This would make changes in political direction transparent instead of allowing support to shift without a reassessment.

5.5 Theoretical Contribution and Generalizability

The findings in this thesis support existing research on megaprojects, policy failure and implementation. Weak cost estimates, unrealistic schedules, political commitment and stakeholder conflicts are already established problems in the literature. The contribution of this thesis is not the identification of completely new variables but in showing how these established problems interacted within one Swedish political and institutional context. The empirical material shows that the characteristics did not simply appear alongside one another.

They created a process where decisions made in one area influenced the development of problems in another. It also shows the importance of the mandate-design phase. Several of the later implementation problems were connected to Dir. 2014:106. The short timetable, broad objectives and large number of participating actors were present before the negotiations had fully started.

For path dependency, the findings show how early political commitments can continue to influence later implementation even when problems become more visible. The case also shows that an established political direction can be maintained not only because changing direction becomes more difficult but also because the justification for continuing the project can change over time. This adds a political dimension to how path dependency developed within the case. When the socio-economic arguments became weaker, other reasons such as capacity, housing, climate, modernization and regional development became more important. This helped the project continue even when parts of its original justification were increasingly questioned. For policy network theory, the case shows how the relationships between the state, municipalities, regions and public agencies created conditions for later conflicts. Its original design required actors with different resources and responsibilities to coordinate, while differences in participation became visible during implementation This thesis contributes to implementation research by showing how decisions made during the initial policy design can shape later implementation problems. In this case, the mandate required coordination between many actors within a short timetable and without sufficiently clear analytical standards, creating difficult conditions for the later implementation process.

The analysis also showed that the analytical characteristics were not always clearly separated. This was mainly visible for external influence where some apparently external problems were partly shaped by the project's own governance design. This shows that the characteristics can overlap in practice and that project design can affect how external conditions influence implementation. As a single-case study, the findings from this thesis are not statistically generalizable to all megaprojects. Its contribution is analytical because the relationships identified in this case can be examined in other Swedish megaprojects. Research is needed to establish if the same patterns appear in other cases.

5.6 Limitations and Further Research

The first limitation of this thesis is the ongoing nature of the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure. The project had not reached a final outcome by the end of the period examined. The findings therefore concern the governance and implementation process up to 2025 and should not be understood as a final evaluation of the project's final results. The 2025 renegotiation is particularly important. It might represent a change in the project's direction, but it remains to be seen. Future research should examine if the renegotiation represents a real change in the project's direction or if it mainly allows earlier political commitments to continue. This would help show if the factors that continued those commitments remain important or if it's a significant split from the earlier path. The second limitation concerns the material. This thesis mainly relies on written sources, which provide detailed information about formal decisions and political positions but can't completely capture informal negotiations or how actors have experienced the process. Interviews with involved actors could provide further insight into political pressure, informal power relations and how they understood the uncertainty and time pressure in the project. The third limitation is the single-case design. The analytical framework was developed for the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure and has not been applied to other projects. Future research could apply the same five analytical characteristics onto other Swedish megaprojects and make necessary adjustments in order to be compatible. Comparative studies could examine if the relationships identified in this thesis are specific to this case or reflect wider patterns in Swedish infrastructure governance.

Another finding from the empirical analysis is worth noting in relation to the theoretical framework. Flyvbjerg's idea that megaprojects can serve as political legacy-building, the political sublime, [207] might be relevant to the National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure but as the material in this thesis does not provide direct evidence, it remains an interesting area for future research.

[207] Flyvbjerg, 2014, P. 9.

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7. Appendices

Samhällsekonomisk effekt	Nuvärde, miljoner kronor	Persontrafik	Godstrafik
Investeringskostnad			
Höghastighetsbanor enligt Sverigeförhandlingen	-403 300		
Drift och underhåll infrastruktur			
Underhåll	-18 600		
Reinvesteringar	-11 400		
Drift	-500		
Effekter för trafikföretag			
Biljettintäkter	84 500	84 500	
Trafikeringskostnader	-46 700	-46 700	
Effekter för resenärer och godskunder			
Restid och reskostnad; resenärer	111 500	111 500	
Transporttid och transportkostnad godskunder	26 400	0	26 400
Budgeteffekter			
Drivmedelsskatt	-27 100	-7 000	-20 100
Banavgifter	10 600	4 100	6 500
Moms	5 000	5 000	
Externa effekter			
Luftföroreningar o klimatgaser	8 000	3 400	4 700
Trafikolyckor	4 900	2 200	2 700
Marginellt infrastrukturslitage	-7 200	-2 700	-4 500
Buller	10 500		10 500
SUMMA EFFEKTER	150 000		
NETTORESULTAT	-253 200		
NNK	-0,6		

Appendix A, Source*:* Trafikverket (2021). *Samlad effektbedömning: Ny stambana, höghastighetståg (Järna-Almedal, Jönköping-Lund), positionspapperet*. (JTR2205). Borlänge: Trafikverket.

Tabell 2 Samhällsekonomisk analys - sammanfattning

Effekt	Beräknad	Ej beräknad	
	Nuvärde (mnkr)	Bedömning	Beskrivning
Resenärer	149674	Positivt	Ökad kapacitet och ett mer robust system med färre förseningar ger en förbättrad punktlighet. Åtgärden bedöms även medföra tillkommande utrikes resande vilket är inte inkluderat i kalkylen.
Godstransporter	1580	Positivt	Ökad kapacitet och ett mer robust system med färre förseningar ger en förbättrad punktlighet, vilket inte är inkluderat i kalkylen.
Persontransportföretag	102674	Försumbart	Åtgärden bedöms medföra tillkommande utrikes resande vilket är inte inkluderat i kalkylen. Ökat tågresande ger ökade biljettintäkter. Samtidigt minskar biljettintäkter för flygresor.
Trafiksäkerhet	7503	Försumbart	
Klimat	12429	Försumbart	
Hälsa	2331	Försumbart	Åtgärden medför minskat buller och ökad fysisk aktivitet. De negativa effekterna såsom barriäreffekter bedöms vara mindre än de positiva effekterna.
Landskap	-	Negativt	Åtgärden ger stora negativa effekter på landskap, djur och natur i form av intrång, barriäreffekter och buller.
Övriga externa effekter	-3856	Försumbart	Åtgärden bedöms leda till regionalekonomiska effekter men dessa bedöms framförallt bestå av geografiska omfördelningar. Effekten bedöms därför vara försumbar i den samhällsekonomiska kalkylen.
Budgeteffekter	441	Försumbart	Budgeteffekterna påverkas försumbart till följd av ökade och minskade momsintäkter för utrikes tåg- och flygresor.
Inbesparade JA-kostnader	-	Försumbart	
Drift, underhålls- och reinvesteringskostnader under livslängd	-47872	Försumbart	
Samhällsekonomisk investeringskostnad	527260		
Nettonuvärde		**Sammanvägning av ej värderbara effekter**	
	-302356	Försumbart	

	Nettonuvärdeskvot	Nettonuvärde	Kvalitetsbedömning

Huvudanalys	< 0	-302356	Generellt bedöms kvaliteten på kalkylen som god, men kalkylen innehåller ett antal olika osäkerheter som kan påverka resultatet både uppåt och nedåt. Det är svårt att avgöra om de sammantaget innebär en under- eller överskattning av lönsamheten. Vissa osäkerheter påverkar kalkyler för olika åtgärder på liknande sätt och har därför liten betydelse för prioritering av objekt, men påverkar bedömning om absolut lönsamhet. Exempel på detta är utveckling av resandemängder samt investerings- och underhållskostnaderna. Andra osäkerheter är mer specifika för Nya Stambanor som osäkerheter kopplade till den trafikering som ligger till grund för kalkylen. Det är möjligt att andra trafikupplägg skulle kunna ge både större eller mindre nyttor än de som redovisas i kalkylen. En annan osäkerhet gäller storleken på nyttor för godstrafiken. Nyttorna för godstrafiken har sen analysen som gjordes i Sverigeförhandlingen minskat betydligt, vilket kan förväntas då kalkylförutsättningarna har uppdaterats. Däremot finns det en viss osäkerhet i om minskningen ska vara så stor som denna analys indikerar. Det finns även osäkerheter kring effekter avseende överflyttning av resenärer från flyg till tåg. Utöver osäkerheter i de effekter som ingår i kalkylen finns även effekter som inte ingår i kalkylen därför att de är svåra att beräkna eller värdera, som effekter i form av minskade förseningar, tillkommande utrikesresor och intrång. Sammantaget bedöms de inte påverka den sammanvägda bedömningen att JA är samhällsekonomiskt olönsamt.
KA högre invkostnad	< 0	-440498	
KA Trafiktillväxt 0%	< 0	-434656	**Motivering till samhällsekonomisk lönsamhet**
Trafiktillväxt +50%	< 0	-244985	Den samhällsekonomiska kalkylen pekar på att åtgärden är samhällsekonomiskt olönsam. Det finns osäkerheter i kalkylen och ett antal effekter som inte värderats i kalkylen. Dessa kan påverka kalkylen både uppåt och nedåt, men bedöms inte vara av en sådan storlek att de kan ändra den sammanvägda lönsamheten från olönsam till lönsam. Det samlade värdet av effekter som inte ingår i kalkylen är svårt att bedöma eftersom det är både positiva effekter, t ex minskade förseningar, tillkommande utrikesresor, och negativa effekter som intrång i landskapet. Nettoeffekten av de ej beräknade effekterna har därför bedömts som försumbar. Den sammanvägda samhällsekonomiska analysen pekar därför mot att investeringen är olönsam. Inte heller de känslighetsanalyser som genomförts för att analysera hur robust resultatet är för olika förändringar av förutsättningarna påverkar den slutsatsen. Mot bakgrund av detta är bedömningen att JA är samhällsekonomiskt olönsam.
Ökning av infrastrukturkostnad med branschindex	< 0	-409000	
Diskonteringstidpunkt och byggstart 2022, trafikstart 2037	< 0	(-175000) - (-151000)	
Sammanvägd samhällsekonomisk lönsamhet			Olönsam

Appendix B, Source*:* Trafikverket (2016). *Samhällsekonomisk kalkyl av höghastighetsjärnväg enligt The National Negotiation on Housing and Infrastructure 2016-02-01*. (TRV 2014/54842). Borlänge: Trafikverket.